

STARFALL

THE ASCENT

Lore Bible · Version 2

The whole game as it stands: mythology, cast, systems, the full Chapter 1 script, and the Chapter 2 plan

Version 2 · 13 November 2026 · Replaces Lore Bible v1 and Lore Updates v1.1

Internal reference. Contains every spoiler.

READ ME FIRST

How to use this bible

This is the single source of truth for STARFALL: THE ASCENT as it exists in the game today (build of 13 November 2026). It merges Lore Bible v1, the v1.1 lore updates, every rename since, the eight playable characters as implemented, the game systems and what they mean in-world, the **complete Chapter 1 script with every line of dialogue and every player choice**, and a proposed plan for Chapter 2.

Tag	Meaning
[CANON]	Decided and in the game, or decided for the story. Write against it.
[DRAFT]	Strong direction. Can still change while writing chapters.
[OPEN]	Not decided. Do not reveal or contradict it yet.
[PROPOSED]	New in v2: proposals for Chapter 2 and beyond. Not decided.

Conflicts. Where v1 and v2 disagree, v2 wins. Where this bible and the game disagree, the game is the record of what players see; flag the conflict and decide.

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> *“Humanity searched the stars for where they belonged. The stars were only ever meant to remind them where they came from.”*

PART 1

Thesis, tone and what the game is

Genre. A top-down action RPG with party switching (three on a team, one on the field), playable in the browser and as an iPhone home-screen app. Story chapters mix cutscenes, walk-around scenes, and missions (fights, escorts, defenses, stealth, frozen-time puzzles). Battle mode offers Rifts, a weekly boss, Trials, a roguelite Climb and Practice.

Thesis. A person is not their chart, their past, or even their memories alone. The final question of the game is not “who was I?” but “who do I choose to be now?” **[CANON]**

Tone. Warm found-family banter on top of cosmic dread. Characters joke under pressure (Bram apologizing to a crate, Theo’s “mostly real money”), and the jokes stop when it matters. The horror is quiet and institutional: forms, windows, stamps, numbered queues, and a city that keeps forgetting. **[CANON]**

Inspiration vs. invention. STARFALL borrows shapes from Sethian and Valentinian Gnosticism (Monad, Aeons in pairs, Sophia, the Demiurge, planetary rulers), Plato’s Myth of Er (Lethe), Greek *chronos* vs *kairos*, astrology, and the institutional history of the Church (indulgences, inquisitions, buried texts). It is its own fictional religion. The Concord Church critiques the abuse of religious power, never faith or believers. Many believers in the game are kind and sincere. **[CANON]**

Real tradition (simplified)	What STARFALL does with it
Gnostic myth: the Monad, Aeons in pairs, Sophia’s error, the Demiurge (Yaldabaoth), Archons	Sophia creates the physical realm alone; the Demiurge only orders it. Kairos is Sophia’s missing partner Aeon. Planetary rulers are “Kosmokrators”; “Archon” is the heretics’ word.
Ophite/Sethian lists of seven rulers (Yaldabaoth, Iao, Sabaoth, Adonaios, Astaphaios, Ailoaios, Horaios)	We fix our own planet pairing (Part 3).
Gnostic readings of the Eden serpent as a revealer	The Serpent is a sliver of Kairos’s divine consciousness left outside time.
Myth of Er: Lethe (forgetting) before rebirth	The Wheel of Return; and, in Meridian, the Mercy: holy water that wears memory away.
Chronos (measured time) vs kairos (the decisive moment)	The Demiurge’s power is measured time; Kairos is the moment outside measure.

PART 2

The cosmology

The Monad [CANON]

The source of all existence. It never speaks, never acts on screen, and is never depicted. Every in-world attempt to describe it contradicts the last. That contradiction is the point.

The Divine Realm (the Pleroma) [CANON]

A reality outside time: no before, no after, no measure. Its beings are the Aeons, each an aspect of divine existence. Aeons exist in pairs (syzygies); creation is meant to happen together.

Sophia, the Aeon of Wisdom [CANON]

Brilliant, curious, impatient and ashamed. Her error was creating alone, without her partner. From that act came the Physical Realm (beautiful, vast, formless and unfinished) and the being who would inhabit it: the Demiurge. She cannot enter the Physical Realm directly: anything that enters is measured, numbered and charted. She can only reach in where time breaks: dreams, déjà vu, eclipses, the minute between ticks. Her help is sincere but not selfless. She wants to be forgiven and avoids admitting how much of the suffering is her doing.

Kairos, the Aeon of the Moment [DRAFT]

The deepest secret of the game. Kairos is Sophia's missing partner: the Aeon she did not wait for. When he saw what she had made alone, he descended to fix it, took a body, and was caught by the Wheel. He has been living, dying and forgetting ever since. Because he is not one of the Demiurge's creations, the Wheel never fully holds him; each life he remembers a little more than he should.

The Serpent [DRAFT]

When Kairos descended, a sliver of his consciousness stayed outside time. It has no body and no chart, so it can speak to humans in any era: the voice in Eden, the voice in dreams ("You were there"). Its message is always the same: "You have forgotten where you came from." It is talking to itself. Final reveal: the Serpent and Kairos are one being. In the current game the Serpent speaks in the Climb (battle mode). In Chapter 1, "You were there" is said by **the Voice**, the light-clock. **[OPEN]** Whether the Voice, the Serpent and the divine self are one presence or three facets.

PART 3

The Demiurge and the Celestial Order

"Sophia made the house. The Demiurge made the rules." [CANON]

Sophia's realm was raw: matter without law, light without rhythm. The Demiurge gave it order: orbits, seasons, cause and effect, and above all time. His claim "I made all of this" is false, but his pride is not baseless.

- He woke alone in a dark, half-made universe and built order because he was afraid.
- He cannot perceive the Divine Realm. He sincerely believes a soul that leaves the Wheel ceases to exist. In his eyes the Wheel saves souls from oblivion.
- He loves his creation like a lonely child loves a model: he would rather break it than let it change.
- His power is Chronos, measured time. His seat is Saturn. The Church calls him the Founder or the First Measure; heretics say Demiurge; old texts say Yaldabaoth.
- **Reveal schedule [CANON]:** never named or hinted in Chapter 1. He is the hidden author of the Mercy rain and fountain (Part 4).

His arc: redeemable [CANON]

He is not destroyed. The final chapters move from fighting him to reaching him. His deepest fear is learning he is not God and that he has a mother who left him. When he accepts the truth he passes into the Divine Realm: the first being the Wheel lets go willingly, and mother and son meet for the first time.

The Kosmokrators [CANON]

Sophia made the planets with living powers inside them as gifts. The Demiurge employed them, giving each an office: assign charts, keep the Wheel turning, hold what souls forget. They are civil servants of a cosmic government, which is why they talk like clerks ("Intake Window 1. Take a number."). They are drowning: every forgotten grief, love and lullaby goes to them to hold, and their overflow falls as Vices. "What you forget does not vanish. It is carried."

Planet	Kosmokrator	Original gift	Office in the Order	Holds / Vice it sheds
Moon	Horaios (met in Ch1)	Dreams, cycles, rest	The Gate: processes the dead, removes memories (Intake Window 1)	Every life's last day · Waxer
Mercury	Ailoaios	Speech, messages, learning	Records and transmits the charts	Forgotten words, names, promises · Gossip
Venus	Astaphaios	Love, beauty, desire	Binds souls to what they want	Forgotten loves · Devourer
Sun	Adonaios	Life, identity, warmth	Assigns each soul its "self"	Forgotten pride · Spotlight
Mars	Sabaoth	Courage, will, strength	Enforces the Order (the war-arm)	Forgotten anger · Hothead
Jupiter	Iao	Fortune, growth, meaning	Hands out each life's lot	Forgotten hope and greed · Collector
Saturn	(the Demiurge's throne)	Structure, endurance	Time itself; seat of the First Measure	Everything else · Deadline

The Silent Spheres [DRAFT]

Uranus, Neptune and Pluto exist in Sophia's creation but were never brought under the Order. The Demiurge cannot see them clearly. Their influence is rare and wild (in gameplay: the Uranus and Neptune Blessings). Late in the story they may be doors out of the Wheel. **[OPEN]** Who placed them there.

PART 4

The Wheel, the Mercy and the Vices

Origin of humanity [CANON]

The Demiurge shaped human bodies from the clay of Sophia's world (Big Boy Bram's Ultimate theme "First Clay" echoes this). The bodies would not wake. He breathed into them the only life he had: light inherited from his mother, without knowing it was hers. Every soul that escapes takes a little of that light out of his universe for good. If everyone left, he would go dark. His fear is ideology, survival and loneliness at once.

Messenger souls [DRAFT]

A few souls came directly from the Divine Realm and got caught in the Wheel. They remember more easily and dream more vividly. Kairos is the greatest of them. **[OPEN]** Candidates: Dr. Naomi Lark (the v1 "Sophia Arden"), Lyra, someone in the Church.

System	What it really is
Birth chart (Registry record) [CANON]	The address of a life inside the Order: hour and minute of birth, signs, Houses. In Meridian it decides your school, work and who you may marry. Every child is registered within the hour. The Church teaches "your chart is you".
Planets / Signs / Houses / Aspects	Planets are offices, Signs are dialects, Houses are rooms, Aspects are relationships between offices. Each playable character has a Sun, Moon and Rising sign and an Aspect.
The Wheel of Return [CANON]	Birth (filed), then a life, then death at the Gate of the Moon (Horaios) ☐ memories removed and handed to the Kosmokrators ☐ the cleaned soul is sent down with a new chart.
Vices [CANON]	Forgotten memories that overflow from a saturated Kosmokrator, shaped by that planet. Their cores hold real fragments of people. Every Vice is someone's lost memory (Dess's core plays her mother's voice).
Starfall / rifts [CANON]	Overflow falling to Earth as Vices through rifts. The Sky Seam over Meridian grows every year. Starfalls happen every night; the Garrison's rooftop guns stop most of them.
The First Starfall	Also the name of the war that began ~100 years ago when the planets were turned against humanity.

The Mercy [CANON] (replaces v1's "Blotting")

- Twenty years ago, on the night of the cold open, a rain fell on Meridian. The next morning a fountain had risen out of the stones of what is now Festival Square.
- The Concord Church claimed it as a gift from Heaven and the source of its authority. Its water is **the Mercy**: handed out at Sunday services, at the yearly Festival of the Mercy, and in silver cups at life events (adoptions, funerals).
- **The water is the curse.** It wears memory away. The more often someone drinks, the more they forget. Not a single instant wipe: the rain, plus twenty years of people drinking.
- The Demiurge made the rain and the fountain. Hidden: never named or hinted in Chapter 1.
- Reveal schedule: Chapter 1 clues only (never state it) · **Chapter 2: the reveal that people forget because of the holy water** · later: the Demiurge is behind it.

Who	Relationship to the water	Clue on screen (Ch1)
Old Matteo	Never misses a Sunday	Forgetful, loses his glasses; asks Kairos to read his own note
Bram's mother	Never misses a Sunday	Called Bram "Tomas", his brother's name
Sister Cassie	Every Sunday since age 6	Can't remember her mother's face ("the Office calls that grace")
Lucas	One silver cup at his adoption	Slept two days; lost all memory of Kairos
Tessa's mother	Drinks at the Festival	Forgets why she came crying
Rosa	Stopped after her husband's funeral	Sharp; "tastes like pennies"

Who	Relationship to the water	Clue on screen (Ch1)
Fish vendor	Works Sundays	Sharp; knows every price
Agnes	Works every Sunday “on purpose”	Sharp
Naomi, Theo	Skip the Festival; Naomi checks Theo drinks nothing	Sharp; Naomi notices patients forgetting birthdays
Kairos	A spoon every Sunday at the orphanage	Felt nothing, forgets nothing (unrecorded: the water can’t touch him)

Lethe. v1’s “Lethe” springs and Mother Noa’s sect are not in the game. The Mercy now fills that role in Meridian. In battle mode the Climb’s healing room is the “Mercy Fountain” (full heal and revive, at the cost of one Blessing level): drinking costs you something. **[DRAFT]**

PART 5

Kairos, his lives, and his divine self

Life	What happened
Life A (~100 years ago)	First Gnosis: awakens completely and confronts the Demiurge. War is declared: the First Starfall. Dies in the war. Meridian becomes the last free city.
Life B (~100 to 20 years ago)	Reborn and remembers. Spends decades rebuilding in secret; founds the memory research the Institute descends from. Attempts a mass awakening. Dies on the night of the rain. His handwriting survives (the vision at the dead clock: “a man’s hand, writing by candlelight. My handwriting. But older.”).
Life C (now, age 20)	Born in the minute time was stopped (11:59). No hour, no stars, no Houses: “the Unwritten”. Left on the steps of St. Hesper’s Orphanage. Remembers everything. The Mercy cannot touch him.

The man in the black cloak = Kairos’s divine self [CANON]

- Life B died on the night of the rain. His **divine self did not**. The cloaked man carried the newborn (life C) to St. Hesper’s and has watched over that body since. To the baby: “Don’t drink the water. And this time… finish it.”
- **His goal:** to return to his physical body. (“Then I go home.”) Whether that means joining with Kairos or replacing him stays **[OPEN]**; play the tension.
- **He can only act on the world while time is stopped.** Outside the stopped minute he works through others (Lyra).
- **The Voice** (the clock made of light) is the divine self’s light form. It gave Kairos its two clock hands, which became his blades. Kairos’s chest mark, the Voice and the cloaked man’s mark are all **a clock face with no hands**.
- **Kairos does not stop time himself.** The divine self holds the minute for him (“Every time I hold the minute, the sky tears a little more”). Kairos believes it is his power at first; in Chapter 1 he notices “someone is holding it with me”. The cloaked man: “Three times. He thinks it’s his.”
- Childhood stops: the ticking Kairos heard as a child, and the stopped kitchen fire at age 9, were the divine self holding the minute. Each stop draws Vices (Vices on the orphanage roof the night of the fire).

Kairos in play

Main DPS with twin blades (the clock hands). No Rising sign, so his Entrance “Borrowed Hour” copies whoever he switched from at 120%. His passive “Undertow” slows Vices. His Ultimate stops time (3 seconds) and fills his combo with finishers. Story gameplay gives him short time-stop missions (Chase the Voice, Breakout stealth, The Frozen Fire).

PART 6

History: the true version and the Church's version

When	What really happened	What the Church teaches
Before time	Sophia creates alone; the Demiurge wakes, orders the universe and makes time.	The Founder made everything from nothing.
The First Room (Eden)	The first souls are filed into the Wheel. The Serpent: "you have forgotten where you came from."	Humanity fell by listening to a demon.
The Tower (Babel)	An early civilization nears collective Gnosis; the scattering of languages is an earlier, smaller forgetting.	Pride punished.
The Drowning (Flood)	The first recorded overflow of the planets, remembered wrongly as water.	Purification by water.
The Thief of Fire	A Kosmokrator (perhaps Sabaoth) gives humanity knowledge against orders and is chained.	A rebel spirit, rightly bound.
~100 years ago	Life A's Gnosis; the First Starfall war. Everything past the Wall falls.	A heretic's rebellion angered the heavens.
~80 years ago	Nobody has mapped past the Wall since.	Maps stop at the Wall.
20 years ago, 11:52–11:59 PM	Life B's attempt; rifts over the Market Ring and harbor; hundreds of Vices. At 11:59 the divine self stops time and leaves life C at St. Hesper's. The Mercy rain falls; the fountain rises by morning. Rifts close "one by one before morning. Nobody can say why."	Heaven wept on the city, and the fountain rose: the Mercy.
11 years ago	Kitchen fire at St. Hesper's; time stops; Kairos (9) pulls Lucas out and burns his hands. Vices on the roof that night. Chancellor Crane comes for "the boy who counts", takes Lucas instead; a silver cup erases Kairos from Lucas.	An adoption.
Present	Chapter 1 (Part 14).	Heretics destroyed the Registry and kidnapped the Chancellor's son.

A deliberate grey area
Life B's mass awakening was not purely heroic. Remembering everything at once was more than minds could bear. Kairos must face that his past self was partly wrong, and that the Demiurge was not wrong about everything.

PART 7

Setting: Meridian, the last free city

Meridian is the last free city on the continent of **Aster**. Past the Wall, nothing has been mapped in 80 years. Vices fall every night; the Garrison's rooftop guns stop most of them before they reach the streets. Above the city hangs the **Sky Seam**, a thin pink scratch that has grown every year. **[CANON]**

Place	What it is	Where it appears
Market Ring	Stalls, the crane over the fruit stalls, the clock tower that chimes nine. Kairos's errands.	Ch1 Scenes 1–4; District "3rd House · Gemini"; Rift "Market Ring Waves"
St. Hesper's Orphanage	Where Kairos grew up. The gate clock stopped at 11:59 forever. The old clock tower is the party's hideout.	Cold open; Scene 9 flashback; Scene 11
Ash Lane	The road to St. Lucia's; rooftops and a lodging house.	Scene 5 escort; Scene 10 Inquisitor; Rift "Ash Lane Blaze"
St. Lucia's Hospital	Naomi's ER, east ward.	Scene 6 defense; Rift "St. Lucia's Ward"
Concord Office	Marble floors, cabinets to the ceiling: "the whole city on paper".	Scene 7; District "10th House · Capricorn"
The Institute	Dr. Marr's Vice research, third sub-level: glass tanks of cores.	Scene 8 and breakout; Rift "Institute Overload"
Festival Square	The Mercy Fountain. Festival of the Mercy each year.	Scene 12; District "5th House · Leo"; Rift "Festival Sparks"
Registry of Births	Every birth record in Meridian, floors deep ("the Stacks"); at the bottom, a vault: INTAKE WINDOW 1. Destroyed at the end of Ch1.	Scenes 13–14; boss arena "Registry Hall"
Garrison Yard	Training ground of the Meridian Garrison.	Training; District "1st House · Aries"; Rift "Garrison Yard"
The Cloister · Drowned Canals	Church cloister; fog-bound canals.	Districts "7th House · Libra", "12th House · Pisces"
The Wall	The edge of the known world.	Mentioned in Scene 11

PART 8

The Concord Church: the dirty side

The official faith of Meridian, bound to the Concord Council (government). It critiques institutions, not believers. Big Boy Bram's family faith and Cassie's vows are sincere and warm. **[CANON]**

- "Your chart is your calling." To question your chart is pride.
- Forgetting is mercy. The Mercy water is Heaven's gift ("Drink, and be forgiven. Drink, and let it go.").
- The Founder is the one true God; the planets are his angels; suffering is their just anger.
- The Serpent is the Adversary; Gnosis is "the Old Heresy".
- A person with no birth record "was never meant to exist. The Church corrects mistakes." (Sister Cassie, Scene 10)

Practice	What it looks like	What it really does
The Mercy	Free holy water at services, festivals, adoptions, funerals.	Wears memory away. Keeps the city docile and forgetful.
The Office of Correction	Protects the faith from heresy. Agents like Sister Cassie, chained fire censers.	An inquisition. Father Vane will burn a lodging house of families to catch the Unwritten.
Re-charting	Corrects "clerical errors" in birth records.	Rewrites who a person is allowed to be. Used on orphans, rebels and heirs.
The Ledger & Confession	Every citizen keeps a Ledger; confessions are "sealed".	Copied to the Registry. The state knows everyone's secrets. **[DRAFT]**
Relics	Sanctified Vice cores sold as charms.	Trade in people's lost memories. **[DRAFT]**
The Buried Books	Officially do not exist.	Heretic scriptures hidden beneath old chapels. The true history. **[DRAFT]**

PART 9

Factions and powers in Meridian

Faction	Who	Stance at end of Ch1
Concord Council	Chancellor Augustin Crane (head), clerks of the Concord Office	Publicly blames the party for destroying the Registry and "kidnapping" Lucas. Crane knows more of the truth than anyone in Meridian.
Concord Church	Father Ambrose Vane, the Office of Correction, priests at the fountain	Hunts the Unwritten. Lost Cassie.
The Institute	Dr. Ezekiel Marr	Studies (and makes use of) Vice cores; experimented on Kairos; lost his daughter Dess, his key card and his subject.
Meridian Garrison	Sgt. Agnes Calder, Cpl. Bram, rooftop gunners	Agnes and Bram are now fugitives with Kairos. The Garrison as a whole is still loyal to the Council.
The cloaked man and Lyra	Kairos's divine self; Lyra, his watcher	Watching. "It's too early. He has to come to me on his own this time."
The Kosmokrators	Horaios (Moon) met in person	Horaios "moved inside the stopped minute": "the Moon remembers me… he's awake." He took Lucas through the Gate.
The party (unnamed)	Kairos, Agnes, Bram, Naomi, Theo, Dess, Cassie (+ Lucas, taken)	Seven on a rooftop at dawn, wanted. Goal: get Lucas back. **[OPEN]** A name for the group.

PART 10

The playable cast (as implemented)

Eight playable characters. Each has a Sun, Moon and Rising sign (Kairos has no Rising), an Aspect, a role, a passive, a team passive, an Entrance (fires on switch-in), a basic combo with a charged hold, a Sun skill (offense), a Moon skill (defense or support), an Aspect combo (Sun and Moon within 4 seconds), and an Ultimate.

Kairos · Main DPS

20 · errand runner from St. Hesper's, the Unwritten. Left as a newborn under a stopped clock. He hates clocks without knowing why, remembers everything, and sometimes sees things a moment before they happen.

Chart: Sun Pisces · Moon Cancer · Rising none (unrecorded) · Aspect Trine **Stats (Lv 1):** HP 120, ATK 12, DEF 16%, 3.4 attacks/s, Close range.

Story: Errand runner who remembers everything; hears the tick; born in the stopped minute. Ch1: gets the blades, is studied by Marr, frees himself with help, loses Lucas to Horaios. Wants: to finish what he doesn't yet understand; to get Lucas back.

Kit	Name	What it does
Signature		Undertow: every hit slows a Vice's movement and attacks. Slowed Vices he hits take +10% damage from everyone for 3s.
Passive	Undertow	Every hit slows the Vice's movement and its attacks for 1.5s.
Team passive	Pull of the Tide	Slowed Vices he hits take 10% more damage from the whole team for 3s.
Entrance	Borrowed Hour	He has no Rising, so he copies the Entrance of whoever he switched from, at 120% power. If he enters first, he dashes in with a slash.
Basic (tap / hold)	Clock Hands	A fast 3-hit combo with both blades. The 3rd hit is a spinning finisher (200%). **Hold:** Crosscurrent: a short jump forward into a wide spinning slash (220%).
Sun skill	Riptide	Dashes through a line of enemies for heavy damage (300%) and leaves a slowing water trail. Can be used twice: the second dash must come within 3s.
Moon skill	Shell	A wide water pulse (120%), +10% ATK for 6s, and a short counter stance. If something hits him in the next 1.2s, he blocks it and releases a huge pulse (320%).
Aspect combo	Trine · Flow	Use both skills in a row: his next 3 basic attacks are all finishers.
Ultimate	The Unwritten Minute	Stops time for 3 seconds. Then Overflow for 8s: +35% damage, and his next 10 basic attacks are all finishers.

Sgt. Agnes Calder · Sub DPS · Sniper

31 · sergeant, Meridian Garrison. Dry, sharp and always in control. Would never admit she looks after her squad like an older sister.

Chart: Sun Capricorn · Moon Scorpio · Rising Sagittarius · Aspect Sextile **Stats (Lv 1):** HP 85, ATK 13, DEF 8%, 1.25 attacks/s, Long range.

Story: Sergeant, 31. Works every Sunday "on purpose" (avoids the Mercy). Pragmatic, dry, protective of Bram ("Fourteen Vices. He had a shield and no plan."). Ch1: first to fight beside Kairos; chooses not to fight Council guards so she can rescue him later.

Kit	Name	What it does
Signature		Spotted: marked enemies take +15% damage from everyone. On the bench, she keeps sniping.

Kit	Name	What it does
Passive	Overwatch	While on the bench she snipes the strongest Spotted enemy (or the closest one) every 2 seconds.
Team passive	Sergeant	While she is in the party, switching characters recharges faster (1s to 0.7s).
Entrance	Overwatch Drop	Fires a piercing shot at each of up to 3 nearby enemies as she lands (aims itself). Everything hit is Spotted.
Basic (tap / hold)	Rifle	Slow, heavy shots that aim themselves. If you're moving, she skips a short step in that direction with each shot. **Hold:** Headshot: a charged piercing shot that aims at the nearest enemy and always crits on Spotted enemies.
Sun skill	Flare	A flare round that Spots every enemy in a wide area. Spotted enemies take 15% more damage from everyone.
Moon skill	Soaking Round	Fires a water shell and rolls back. The splash leaves a pool for 5s: enemies in it are slowed and take 10% more damage.
Aspect combo	Sextile · Crossfire	Flare then Soak: the pool Spots too. Soak then Flare: the flare explodes for damage.
Ultimate	Killzone	For 3s, on or off the field, she fires a heavy shot every 0.8s at the toughest enemy and Spots it.

Big Boy Bram · Shielder · Control

25 · corporal, Meridian Garrison. Huge, clumsy and kind. Apologizes to furniture. Would follow Sergeant Calder into a rift, and has.

Chart: Sun Taurus · Moon Cancer · Rising Sagittarius · Aspect Sextile **Stats (Lv 1):** HP 170, ATK 6, DEF 32%, 1.5 attacks/s, Close range.

Story: Corporal, 25. Huge, gentle, apologizes to crates, makes toast. Faith is warm and sincere; his mother never misses a Sunday and called him Tomas (his brother's name). Followed Agnes into the Eastern Rift. Carries Kairos to St. Lucia's.

Kit	Name	What it does
Signature		Stagger: his hits deal light damage and fill an enemy's Stagger bar. Full bar = stunned for 2s.
Passive	Oops	Every 4 seconds, on the field or from the bench, he stumbles by accident: a little quake around the active character that deals light damage and adds Stagger.
Team passive	Guard Duty	While on the bench he blocks one bullet aimed at the active character every 8 seconds.
Entrance	Coming Through!	Trips into the fight. The shockwave always crits, knocks everyone back and adds a lot of Stagger.
Basic (tap / hold)	Shield Bash	A 5-hit combo of shield shoves. The 5th hit is a slam finisher that fills a lot of Stagger. **Hold:** Plant: slams the shield down (220%) and briefly stuns everything nearby.
Sun skill	Mini Bram	Shapes a goofy clay Bram that stands in front of you, blocks bullets and makes enemies attack it instead.
Moon skill	Hold the Line	Gives the active character a big shield worth 40% of Bram's HP. It stays when you switch.
Aspect combo	Sextile · Fortify	Walls and shields last 50% longer, and the wall knocks back anything that hits it.
Ultimate	Bram's Stand	One huge slam (500%) around him, then a shield dome for 6s that keeps pushing enemies out and stunning them. The team deals +15% damage while it stands.

Dr. Naomi Lark · Healer · Buffer

30 · ER doctor at St. Lucia's. Precise and permanently tired. Writes the things she's afraid of forgetting on her arm. Married to Theo.

Chart: Sun Virgo · Moon Taurus · Rising Cancer · Aspect Trine **Stats (Lv 1):** HP 90, ATK 7, DEF 15%, 2.4 attacks/s, Mid range.

Story: ER doctor, 30, married to Theo. Writes the scary truths on her arm "because by tonight I'll have talked myself out of it." Notices patients forgetting their birthdays. Skips the Festival; checks Theo drinks nothing.

Kit	Name	What it does
Signature		Adrenaline: her skills heal and boost the team's attack.
Passive	Notes on My Arm	Her healing is 30% stronger on anyone below 40% HP.
Team passive	Lark & Lark	If Theo is in the party, every damage buff either of them gives lasts 50% longer.
Entrance	House Call	Heals the whole team (bench too) for 10% of their HP as she arrives.
Basic (tap / hold)	Chem Darts	Darts of water chemicals. The target takes a little water damage every second for 3s. **Hold:** Splash Vial: the same chemicals as a small area burst at the nearest enemy.
Sun skill	Triage	One quick heal for the whole team (12%), and +20% damage for 8s.
Moon skill	Recovery Field	A healing zone for 6s. Whoever stands in it heals 3% HP every second; the bench heals slowly too. Slows enemies.
Aspect combo	Trine · Steady Hands	For 6s, any healing above full HP turns into a shield.
Ultimate	Code Blue	Revives every downed ally at 40% HP, heals everyone 40%, and gives +25% damage for 10s.

Theo Lark · Support DPS · Inventor

31 · rift researcher nobody takes seriously. Talks too fast, believes the impossible, and builds machines out of whatever he finds. Married to Naomi.

Chart: Sun Aquarius · Moon Gemini · Rising Leo · Aspect Trine **Stats (Lv 1):** HP 88, ATK 8, DEF 12%, 2.6 attacks/s, Mid range.

Story: Rift researcher, 31, Naomi's husband. Wild hair, beeping brass box, turrets in his bag. Measured the lost minute and traced it to Kairos. Hires Kairos as his assistant ("mostly real money").

Kit	Name	What it does
Signature		Calibrated: while a turret is up, he and his machines deal +20% damage.
Passive	Calibrated	While one of his turrets is up, everything Theo and his machines hit takes 20% more damage.
Team passive	Show-off	When one of his machines gets a kill, the active character gains a little Ultimate energy.
Entrance	Field Test	Drops a little fan drone that blasts enemies with air for 8s.
Basic (tap / hold)	Air Pistol	Mid-range compressed-air shots. Aims itself at the nearest enemy. **Hold:** Pressure Burst: a blast of air that hits up to 3 enemies at once.
Sun skill	Wind Turret	Builds a turret that fires once a second at enemies in its range for 12s. It keeps working while Theo is on the bench.
Moon skill	Overclock	Team +10% damage and +10% attack speed for 8s. His machines fire 50% faster.
Aspect combo	Trine · Eureka	His turrets last 50% longer.
Ultimate	Big Idea	Summons a walking machine that fights next to you with missiles for 9s.

Lucas Crane · Main DPS · Long range

20 · senior clerk at the Concord Office, the Chancellor's adopted son. Cold, controlled, and hard to reach. Grew up with Kairos in the orphanage, forgot him, and swore never to again.

Chart: Sun Scorpio · Moon Capricorn · Rising Virgo · Aspect Sextile **Stats (Lv 1):** HP 90, ATK 16.5, DEF 10%, 1.9 attacks/s, Long range.

Story: Senior clerk, 20, the Chancellor's adopted son. Grew up with Kairos at St. Hesper's; the Chancellor chose him when Kairos was sick from the fire; a silver cup of the Mercy erased Kairos from his mind. Remembers through bread and the cat joke, defects, gets the party into the Institute, makes a vow ("I'm not losing you twice") and is taken by Horaios in Kairos's place. Last seen at Window 1, unable to write his own name.

Kit	Name	What it does
Signature		Vow: with Kairos in the party, switching between them shields the one coming in, and Drowsy enemies take +25% from Lucas.
Passive	Double Tap	After a Lance Shot, 50% chance to fire a second one alongside it at half damage.
Team passive	Covering Fire	If Kairos is in the team, Lucas fires from the bench every time Kairos lands a finisher. (The Vow still holds: once per fight he takes a killing blow meant for Kairos.)
Entrance	Cold Entry	Fires a fan of stone shards and gives a small shield (8% HP).
Basic (tap / hold)	Frost Pistol	A slow 4-shot combo that aims itself. The 4th shot is a big piercing finisher (300%). **Hold:** Lance Shot: a charged piercing shot (320%) at the nearest enemy.
Sun skill	Ricochet	An ice round (220%) that bounces to up to 3 more enemies within range.
Moon skill	Composure	Deploys an ice decoy that draws enemies for 10s. He gets a small shield and +30% crit chance for 10s.
Aspect combo	Sextile · Discipline	Using both skills in a row: his crits deal 50% more damage for 6s.
Ultimate	Petrify	Turns every enemy in a wide area to stone for 3s, then shatters them for big damage.

Sister Cassie Vire · Burn DPS · Healer

21 · former agent of the Office of Correction. A true believer who saw what the Church calls mercy, and broke her chain. Fierce, blunt, all or nothing.

Chart: Sun Sagittarius · Moon Virgo · Rising Aries · Aspect Square **Stats (Lv 1):** HP 105, ATK 9, DEF 18%, 2 attacks/s, Mid range.

Story: Former agent of the Office of Correction, 21. Has drunk the Mercy every Sunday since six and cannot remember her mother's face. Hesitates when Father Vane orders a lodging house burned; leaves the Church at the Festival ("I've kept my vows my whole life. That's exactly why I can't stay.").

Kit	Name	What it does
Signature		Scorched: her burns hit hard, burning enemies take +10% damage, and allies take 10% less damage while she is in the party.
Passive	Scorched	Her burns hurt much more than normal fire, all burns deal 10% more damage while she's in the team, and burning enemies take 10% more damage from everyone.
Team passive	Sanctuary	While she is in the party, every ally takes 10% less damage.
Entrance	Charge of Faith	Leaps in with a fire slam that sets everything nearby burning.
Basic (tap / hold)	Censer Swings	Wide flail swings that set enemies burning. **Hold:** Thurible Spin: a spinning ring of fire that burns longer.

Kit	Name	What it does
Sun skill	Penance	Hurls the censer like a meteor. The area burns for 6s.
Moon skill	Absolution	A small heal on the active character (12%) and a cleanse. Every burning enemy nearby takes a burst of fire damage.
Aspect combo	Square · Zeal	Penance then Absolution: double heal. Absolution then Penance: double fire.
Ultimate	Burn the Mercy	A wave of fire across the field that sets everything burning, and one heal for the team (15%).

Dess Marr · Support · Buffer

20 · lab assistant, Dr. Marr's daughter. Nervous, brilliant and guilty. She learned what her father keeps on his shelves, and took them with her.

Chart: Sun Cancer · Moon Libra · Rising Gemini · Aspect Square **Stats (Lv 1):** HP 80, ATK 8, DEF 6%, 2.4 attacks/s, Mid range.

Story: Lab assistant, 20, Dr. Marr's daughter. Stammers, brilliant, can hear the memories in cores. A core plays a mother saying "little star"; a girl of light with Dess's freckle rises from a core and fights at her side. Steals her father's key card. Suspects the girl is her own forgotten childhood ("I'm smart enough to guess. I'm not brave enough to know.").

Kit	Name	What it does
Signature		Pure support: she barely fights, but makes everyone else hit harder, crit harder and charge their Ultimates faster.
Passive	Steady Hands	While she is in the party, all allies gain Pneuma 20% faster.
Team passive	Team Notes	While she is in the party, all healing and shields are 10% stronger.
Entrance	Unlocked	Gives the active character a small shield (10% HP) as she arrives.
Basic (tap / hold)	Core Pulse	Weak pulses of light from a core. **Hold:** Tide Ring: a small burst of water around her that pushes enemies back and gives only Dess a small shield (12% HP).
Sun skill	Undertow	A small water burst around her (80%). Then for 10s, when any ally attacks, a water pulse bursts around the target (300% of Dess's ATK, slows), at most once every 1.5 seconds.
Moon skill	Clear Sky	An air burst (60%) that pushes enemies back. Then all allies get +10% crit chance and +30% crit damage for 10s.
Aspect combo	Square · Insight	Using both skills in a row: allies get +15% crit chance for 10s.
Ultimate	Recollection	A wave of memories that deals small damage, and every ally deals 30% more damage for 12s.

PART 11

Supporting cast

Character	Who	Thread
The man in the black cloak	Kairos's divine self	Carried the baby; "Don't drink the water. And this time… finish it." Acts only in stopped time. Goal: "Then I go home." Clock face with no hands on his chest.
The Voice	A clock made of light; the divine self's light form	Holds the minute for Kairos; gives him its two hands as blades. "Someone you'll recognize. Not today." "You were there."
Lyra	Non-playable watcher, a girl on the beam	Works for the cloaked man. Warns Kairos not to drink at the Festival. Refuses to say who she is. **[OPEN]** Her identity.
Chancellor Augustin Crane	Head of the Concord Council	Came for "the boy who counts", took Lucas instead ("You'll forget him soon enough. The Church will see to that."). Frames the party.
Dr. Ezekiel Marr	Institute scientist, Dess's father	Smiling cruelty; gaslighting ("You signed. You just don't remember."). Snatches the "little star" core away fast. **[DRAFT]** He took his own daughter's memories.
Father Ambrose Vane	Senior priest, Office of Correction	"Faithful people. They will be forgiven." Throws the fire flask himself. Hands out the Mercy at the Festival.
Horaios	Kosmokrator of the Moon; Ch1 boss	A clerk of moonlight behind a giant desk at Intake Window 1. Moves inside stopped time. "You're not the only one who's done this before." Takes Lucas: "Irregular. But acceptable."
Tessa	Market girl	The girl under the beam. Kairos's first rescue.
Tessa's mother	Flower seller	Drinks at the Festival and forgets why she came crying.
Sister Agathe	Matron of St. Hesper's	Found the baby; gave the orphans a spoon of the Mercy each Sunday.
Old Matteo, Rosa, the fish vendor, the baker	Market Ring regulars	The Mercy clue cast (Part 4). Rosa: "tastes like pennies".
Mrs. Pell, Tomas	Mentioned only	Mrs. Pell bought fish; Tomas is Bram's brother.

PART 12

Enemies

The seven Vices

Vice	Planet · what it is	How it fights
Hothead	Mars · reckless daring	Charger. Flashes red, then rushes in a straight line. Bait it into a wall to stun it.
Gossip	Mercury · deceit	Fast biter. Zigzags in, lunges at you, and splits in two when destroyed.
Waxer	Moon · growing and waning	Healer. Follows wounded Vices to heal them and lobs wax at you. Destroy it first.
Spotlight	Sun · arrogance	Long range. Locks a red line on you, then fires a beam down it. Step off the line.
Deadline	Saturn · the lie that waits	Tank. Walks you down, slams the ground up close, and grows every 10s it survives.
Devourer	Venus · deceptive desire	Stalks you, then blooms: pulls you in and drains HP up close. Dodge out of the pull.
Collector	Jupiter · greed	Thief. Rushes you to steal Pneuma, sprints off, comes back. Destroy it to get the hoard back.

Elites (glowing outline)

Elite	Effect
Hasted elite	Moves 40% faster.
Shielded elite	Has a blue shield that regrows if you stop hitting it.
Volatile elite	Explodes a moment after it dies. Step out of the red circle.

Bosses and named fights

Fight	What happens
Sister Cassie (Ch1, The Inquisitor)	A chained censer that drips fire; punishes standing still.
Horaios, Kosmokrator of the Moon	3 phases in battle mode (Filing Shields from phase 2; Nightmare adds a 4th phase where the Moon Gate pulls you in). In the story: the whole party is “stamped, processed, grey”; only Kairos moves; Horaios moves inside the stopped minute.
Champion (Trial of Mars)	Destroy it within 60 seconds; it recovers if you stop hitting it.

PART 13

Game systems and what they mean in-world

System	How it plays	In-world meaning
Party of three, switching	One character on the field; switching fires that character's Entrance.	The found family, fighting as one.
Pneuma and Ultimates	Gold orbs and perfect dodges fill a shared bar; at 100, the active character's Ultimate.	Pneuma: breath, spirit.
Recollection (character level)	Levels 1–20 from Memories (XP). Memories drop from defeated Vices and are split across the party at the end of a stage. Milestones at Lv 5, 10, 15, 20 are upgrades you awaken.	Each Vice is a lost memory; collecting them makes the party remember who they are.
Skill Mastery	Every match gives Mastery; spend it (plus Stardust) to level Entrance, Basic, Sun, Moon and Ultimate up to Lv 10 (+5% each). A skill cannot exceed the character's level.	Practice.
Star Fragments (Builds)	Gems with a sign, a degree and a slot (Sun, Moon, Rising); element and fit bonuses; salvage for Stardust.	Fragments literally tune a soul's address in the Order.
Blessings (Climb)	Pick planetary Blessings between districts: Saturn Discipline, Uranus Upheaval, Neptune Dissolution, Mercury Swiftness, Venus Devotion, Mars Fury, Jupiter Fortune.	Gifts the planets still give. Uranus and Neptune are the wild Silent Spheres.
Districts (Houses)	1st Garrison Yard (Aries), 3rd Market Ring (Gemini), 5th Festival Square (Leo), 7th The Cloister (Libra), 10th Concord Offices (Capricorn), 12th Drowned Canals (Pisces), each with a rule.	Houses are rooms of a life; Meridian's districts are filed under them.
Mercy Fountain (Climb)	Full heal and revive; one random Blessing level fades. Or walk on.	Drinking costs memory.
Rifts	Daily-condition farming stages: Ash Lane Blaze, St. Lucia's Ward, Institute Overload, Garrison Yard (Fragments); Market Ring Waves (Memories); Festival Sparks (Stardust); Clocktower Drills (Mastery: only skills damage Vices).	Rifts still open across the city after Ch1.
Weekly Horaios	Normal / Hard / Nightmare; weekly Star-born Fragment.	The Gate keeps processing.
Bonds (story)	Talk scenes raise a character's Bond; Bond makes them stronger in story fights.	Who Kairos sits with.
Training (Vigil Yard)	Basics plus a drill for each character (solo kit, then team).	The Garrison trains volunteers.

PART 14

Chapter 1 synopsis: “The Minute Meridian Held Its Breath”

About 40 minutes. Saved at every scene. The full script with every line is Appendix A.

Cold open · The Night the Sky Broke. Twenty years ago, 11:52 PM. Rifts tear open over Meridian; hundreds of Vices. A man in a black cloak walks through the panic carrying a baby. At 11:59 the orphanage clock stops and so does everything. The baby cries at the ticking. He leaves it on the steps of St. Hesper’s: “Don’t drink the water. And this time… finish it.” He vanishes. The clock never moves again; nobody remembers him.

1 · Tuesday Errands. Twenty years later. Kairos reads Old Matteo’s errand list once and runs it around the Market Ring from memory (delivery puzzles at the fish stall, bakery and Rosa’s). Matteo asks him to read the same list again ten minutes later. The Sky Seam is bigger than last spring. He flinches at the nine o’clock bells (the tick under them). A half-second vision: the crane cable snaps over Tessa. (Original v1 summary follows.) Twenty years later. Kairos runs errands in the Market Ring (walk-around: Matteo, the fish vendor, Tessa, the guard, the baker, Rosa). The Sky Seam is longer than last spring. He flinches at the nine o’clock bells (the tick under them). A half-second vision: the crane cable snaps over Tessa.

2 · The Stopped Minute. The cable snaps. Time stops. The Voice, a clock made of light, holds the minute for him and gives him its hands as blades. Gameplay: Chase the Voice, push the beam.

3 · First Blood. Time restarts; everyone gasps for a lost minute of air. The Seam opens: Vices in daylight. Kairos fights by instinct. Sgt. Agnes (rooftop rifle) and Big Boy Bram (shield, crate) join.

4 · Who Are You?. Agnes and Bram believe him. A handless clock mark glows on his chest. He collapses.

5 · Carry Him. Escort along Ash Lane to St. Lucia’s. Bram mentions the Festival; Agnes works every Sunday on purpose.

6 · St. Lucia’s. Revised: the player reads Theo’s brass reader to find where the minute went missing first (district, then the crane gauge, then Kairos himself). Theo’s scope shows the Seam grew a hand’s width at 9:04 (each held minute tears the sky). After the defense, optional Ward Rounds: two of three patients can’t name their birthday. (Original summary follows.) Dr. Naomi Lark writes “patient was glowing” on her arm. Theo bursts in: every clock lost exactly sixty seconds and the center was Kairos. A rift inside the hospital: defense mission; Naomi and Theo join. Theo offers Kairos a job.

7 · The Concord Office. Revised: a walkable queue shows what records do to people (an engaged couple refused for six years, a boy sent to the masons’ school by his House, a widow whose husband’s death is filed wrong) before Lucas reads Kairos’s blank record. (Original summary follows.) Kairos’s birth record is blank: “Congratulations. You don’t exist.” The clerk is Lucas Crane, his childhood roommate, who doesn’t know him. Dr. Marr arrives and takes Kairos “with consent”. Agnes stops Bram fighting the guards.

8 · This Won’t Hurt. Revised: Dess pushes back on Marr’s procedure; Marr explains his own logic (“If a core can say it once, I can make it say it again. Imagine giving it back to them.”); Dess watches which shelf he puts the little star core on. (Original summary follows.) The Institute, third sub-level. Marr gaslights Kairos. Dess, his daughter, brings a core that sings “Come inside, little star” in her mother’s voice. The resonance syncs to Kairos’s pulse.

9 · There Wasn’t a Cat. Revised: the player walks as Lucas (bakery, kitchen window, the empty saucer, the gate clock), then the flashback, then a new scene in the Chancellor’s study (“Everything you have, I gave you.”); Lucas takes his coat without answering. At the safehouse he admits he doesn’t know which version of himself is lying. At the steel door Dess reveals she swapped the little star core for a blank hours earlier (core-listening puzzle). (Original summary follows.) Lucas remembers: the kitchen fire at nine stopped, Kairos burned his hands saving him, the Chancellor took Lucas instead, a silver cup erased Kairos. He goes to the safehouse, gives the breakout plan, joins. Breakout (outside team fights down; Kairos stealths out with three seconds of help). Dess frees the cores; a girl of light with her freckle; Dess joins. Escape.

10 · The Inquisitor. Sister Cassie blocks the rooftops. Fight. Father Vane orders the lodging house burned; Cassie hesitates; Vane throws the flask. Kairos begs whoever is holding the minute: The Frozen Fire, carry three people out in 20 seconds.

11 · The Clock Tower. Revised: a walkable evening. Lucas's talk (required) adds "I don't think I need to be who I was. I just need to be someone who doesn't leave." before the vow. Optional: Agnes's incident report (she leaves Kairos's name out), Theo's drone (hand him the right part), Naomi checks his old burn scars, Bram's toast, Dess and the cores. Each talk raises Bond. The dead clock gives the vision; Lyra; the Mercy spoon memory. (Original summary follows.) Hideout in St. Hesper's dead clock tower. Recap; the Wall and Aster. Bond scenes (pick two): Lucas's vow, Agnes and Bram, Naomi and Theo, Dess and the cores, or Kairos alone at the clock (a vision of his older handwriting: "And this time, finish it."). Lyra on the beam: don't drink anything at the Festival.

12 · Festival of the Mercy. Revised: a walkable festival first (fried dough, a lantern stall with a blank lantern for Kairos, Bram's errand to his mother who calls him Tomas, a widow who sleeps because of the cup, Rosa refusing it, Cassie sincerely defending the Mercy). Then Tessa's mother drinks and forgets; Vane makes Cassie drink in front of the crowd; she feels her anger vanish, asks why it feels like being robbed, leaves, and sets her Office badge on the fountain's rim. (Original summary follows.) The priest hands out the Mercy. Tessa's mother drinks and forgets why she was crying. Cassie confronts Father Vane ("I can't remember my mother's face") and leaves the Church to join the party. An eclipse; five rifts. All eight fight. Every Vice turns toward the Registry of Births.

13 · The Registry. Lucas steals his father's keys. A split two-team descent through the Stacks. At the bottom: INTAKE WINDOW 1. Kairos: "I've been here."

14 · Intake Window 1. Revised: Kairos asks for the minute ("Please. Hold it one more time.") instead of claiming it. After the Gate closes, a silent beat: "Mine doesn't have one. His does now." Bram carries him out. (Original summary follows.) Horaios, a clerk of moonlight. The party is stamped grey; only Kairos moves. Horaios moves inside the stopped minute: "You're not the only one who's done this before." He reaches for Kairos; Lucas breaks through and is taken instead through a gate of white light: "Don't you dare forget me." "I can't. I never forget anything." "Good. Then come get me." The Registry collapses. Dawn: Chancellor Crane frames the party. Coda: Lyra and the cloaked man ("Three times. He thinks it's his." "Then I go home."). Lucas at Window 1 cannot write his own name. **Chapter 2: The Archive.**

PART 15

Player choices and story flags (Chapter 1)

Choices set flags that change later lines. They never change the plot. Bond scenes raise Bond with the chosen characters.

Scene	Choice	Flag	Pays off later
1 (Tessa)	It pays in bread / Somebody has to remember things / I'm collecting favors	c_bread / c_earnest / c_joke	Scene 6 (Theo's job; Tessa's mother's message); Scene 11 (Bram owes three favors)
3 (Agnes)	Keep fighting / Run away screaming / Who are you?	c_ines_fight / c_ines_joke	Scene 4 and the Agnes & Bram bond
6 (Naomi)	No concussion / Kidding, it's Tuesday / Your shoes are untied	c_noemi_joke / c_noemi_sharp	Naomi & Theo bond
7 (Lucas)	We shared a room for nine years / Wrong person	c_truth / c_lie	Scene 9 Lucas's first line
8 (Marr)	Then you go first / Okay / Say nothing	c_marr_joke / c_marr_comply / c_marr_silent	Dess's line at the steel door
10 (Cassie)	I have a name / Do I get a say / Can I finish my bread	c_cass_name / c_cass_joke	Scene 12 Cassie joins
11 (Theo's recap)	Sounds bad / I want breakfast / I have a job now	c_breakfast / c_job	Scene 14 cold toast; "first assignment"
11 (Bond)	Pick two of five talks	Bond levels	Story-fight strength
14 (Theo)	I'll find out / Somewhere I've been before	c_been	Coda: "He has. Many times."

PART 16

Mysteries ledger (status after Chapter 1)

Mystery	Planted in Ch1	Next beat	Reveal
Why does Meridian forget?	Matteo, Bram's mother, Cassie, Lucas's cup, Tessa's mother, Rosa's pennies, Naomi's arm	**Ch2: the Mercy water causes it**	Later: the Demiurge made the rain and fountain
Who is the cloaked man?	Cold open; coda; handless clock on his chest	He acts only in stopped time; Lyra is his agent	Kairos's divine self; wants to "go home"
Who holds the minute?	"Someone's holding it with me"	Kairos tries to stop time alone and can't	The divine self, every time
Who is Lyra?	On the beam; "supposed to be watching"	—	**[OPEN]**
Dess's little star	Her mother's voice in a core; the girl with her freckle	Ch2 **[PROPOSED]**: the core is Dess's own childhood, taken by Marr	Memories can be returned
Has Kairos been here before?	"I've been here." Horaios: "not the only one who's done this before."	Life B's handwriting	Lives A and B
Why does each time stop draw Vices?	Vices on the orphanage roof after the fire; "the sky tears a little more"	—	Stopping measured time strains the Order
What did the Chancellor want?	"The boy who counts. The one with the memory."	—	**[OPEN]** What Crane knows
Where is Lucas?	Through the Moon Gate; a white room; can't write his name	Ch2	The Archive
Who is Kairos?	No Houses; the Unwritten	—	Sophia's partner Aeon (late game)
The Serpent	Not in the Ch1 story (battle-mode Climb only)	Introduce carefully	A sliver of Kairos outside time

PART 17

Open questions

- Does the divine self want to merge with Kairos or replace him? (Play the tension; decide before the midgame.)
- Lyra's identity (a messenger soul? a past companion of life B? connected to Sophia?).
- What Kairos chooses at the end: wake or stay.
- How many cycles of forgetting have happened.
- Who placed the Silent Spheres.
- Whether Naomi is a messenger soul (she inherits v1's Dr. Sophia Arden thread: notes on her arm).
- What the Chancellor knows, and whether Crane has met the cloaked man.
- Whether the Serpent should appear in story chapters, and how it relates to the Voice.
- A name for the party.
- Kosmokrator names other than Horaios are still working names from v1.

PART 18

Chapter 2 plan: “The Archive” [PROPOSED]

Everything in this part is a proposal for discussion. Target: about 45–55 minutes, same structure as Chapter 1 (cutscenes, walk-around scenes, varied missions, two or three bond moments, a Kosmokrator boss).

What Chapter 2 has to do

- **Reveal that the Mercy causes the forgetting** (scheduled for Ch2). Do it through evidence the party gathers, not exposition.
- Rescue Lucas from the Archive, and make the rescue cost something.
- Deepen the divine-self tension: Kairos tries to hold the minute alone and fails; the cloaked man helps without being seen.
- Introduce the second Kosmokrator and the bureaucratic underworld of the Order.
- Give Dess, Cassie and Bram their first personal stakes; keep the Demiurge unnamed.

Premise

The Moon Gate took Lucas into **the Archive**: the place where the Order files every life it processes. It is the “back office” of the Wheel, run by **Ailoaios, Kosmokrator of Mercury** (records, names, messages). Souls brought there are turned into clerks who file other souls, and they slowly forget their own names. Back in Meridian, the Registry of Births is gone: nobody can prove who they are. The Church announces a city-wide **Re-registration**, and every citizen who re-registers receives a cup of the Mercy “so the new record can begin clean”.

Act 1 · Fugitives (Meridian)

- **Cold open:** Lucas at Window 1. A clerk with no face teaches him the rules: “Your name is the last thing you give up. Everyone gives it up.” He writes “L” and stops.
- **Scene 1, The Day After:** the party hides in Theo’s workshop. Wanted posters. Kairos hasn’t slept. Theo starts building a “Gate compass” from Dess’s cores.
- **Scene 2, Re-registration:** walk-around in a queue that circles Festival Square. Citizens are cheerful and blank. Matteo can’t recognize Kairos. Rosa refuses to drink. (Optional talks seed the reveal.)
- **Scene 3, Naomi’s Arm:** Naomi compares her arm notes with hospital charts: the patients who forget most are the ones who drink most. Dess runs fountain water through Marr’s equipment; it resonates exactly like a Vice core. **The reveal.** Cassie, who drank every Sunday, takes it hardest.
- **Mission, The Fountain Raid:** a stealth-and-defense mission at night to steal a sealed barrel of the Mercy from the Church cellars, fighting the Office of Correction (Father Vane as a mid-boss, or his new Inquisitor).
- **Bram’s stake:** his mother is in the Re-registration line. He has to choose between dragging her out (she doesn’t know him) or letting her drink. Bond scene payoff later.

Act 2 · Through the Gate

- Theo’s compass points up at the Sky Seam. The next eclipse is in three days; the party needs a door. Lyra appears and, without explanation, shows them a stopped clock in the Drowned Canals where the Gate “leaks”.
- Kairos tries to stop time to open the leak and cannot do it alone. Lyra waits. The minute stops anyway. (The divine self helps; Kairos does not see him. Lyra: “Say thank you.” “To who?”)
- **The Archive:** endless corridors of filing cabinets, pneumatic tubes, stamped forms drifting like snow. New mechanic **[PROPOSED]**: **Filing**. Inside the Archive each party member slowly gains a “Filed” meter; when it fills they forget a skill until they rest at a lantern. Kairos never fills (he has no record to file).

- Missions: a forms puzzle (find Lucas's file among millions using Kairos's memory), a chase through the tubes, and a defense of a lantern while Dess reads cores to navigate.
- Kairos finds a drawer labeled in his older handwriting: life B's notes on the Archive, written as if to "the next one". One line: "Don't trust the Moon. Trust the Moon's regret."

Act 3 · Window 2

- Lucas is now a clerk at Window 2, processing new arrivals with a stamp. He doesn't recognize anyone. He is efficient and calm, which is worse.
- Horaios appears, damaged and changed since Ch1 ("the Moon remembers"): he did not take Lucas to harm him; he took him because the Order demanded one irregular soul and Lucas offered. Horaios quietly lets the party pass. Not an ally yet; a debt.
- **Boss: Ailoaios, Kosmokrator of Mercury** (working name), the Archivist. Mechanics: rewrites the arena (doors and walls swap), "misfiles" party members (forced switches), speaks in other people's voices. Phase 3: reads Kairos's blank file aloud and finds handwriting in it.
- **The rescue:** Lucas cannot write his name. Kairos remembers it for him, every detail, the bread, the cat that never existed. (Callback to Kairos's Scene 1 line "Somebody has to remember things for them", weighted if the player chose c_earnest.) Lucas writes his name. The file burns.
- **Cost:** one party member stays filed for the escape and loses something real. Proposal: Cassie loses the memory of the Office (freeing, and sad), or Dess learns the little star is her own memory and chooses to give it back to herself.

Ending and hooks

- They come back through the Seam into Meridian at dawn of the eclipse day. The Re-registration has reached half the city.
- Chancellor Crane is waiting, alone. He knew about the Archive. He knew about the cloaked man. "You're not the first boy I've seen with that mark."
- Dess's little star confirmed: Marr took his daughter's childhood to study her ability. Marr disappears with the Institute's core vault.
- Coda: the cloaked man, weaker. "Twice more and I won't be able to hold it at all." Lyra: "Then tell him." "Not yet."
- Final image: the Sun rises wrong (Adonaios, Kosmokrator of the Sun, is next). Chapter 3 tease.

Gameplay additions for Chapter 2

Addition	Notes
Ailoaios boss (Mercury)	Weekly-boss rotation can alternate Horaios / Ailoaios.
Archive district and Rift	New theme (filing halls); Rift "Archive Overflow" could drop Mercury-heavy Fragments.
Filed meter (story only)	Pressure mechanic that rewards switching; Kairos is immune.
Lucas returns	Lucas is unavailable for most of Ch2 (7-character party), returns for the boss; a new Entrance or passive reflecting "remembered".
New Vice	A Mercury clerk Vice that "stamps" you (short silence: no skills).
Bonds	Bram and his mother; Cassie after the reveal; Naomi and Theo's first fight about what to tell the city.

PART 19

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Aeon	A divine being of the Divine Realm; exists in pairs.
Archive, the	Ch2 **[PROPOSED]**: where the Order files processed lives; run by Ailoaios.
Aster	The continent. Meridian is its last free city.
Chronos	Measured time; the Demiurge's power.
Concord Church / Council	Meridian's official faith, bound to the government.
Demiurge	The being Sophia created alone; orderer of the Physical Realm. Church: the Founder, the First Measure. Never named in Ch1.
Divine self	The part of Kairos (life B) that did not die; the man in the black cloak; the Voice.
Gnosis	Remembering you are more than your chart: remember, recognize, unfile.
Intake Window 1	Horaios's desk; where souls are processed.
Kairos	The decisive moment; the Aeon who is Sophia's partner; the main character.
Kosmokrator	A planetary ruler serving the Order. Heretics say "Archon".
Mercy, the	Holy water from the Festival fountain; wears memory away. The Church calls it Heaven's gift.
Pneuma	Breath, spirit: the gold Ultimate bar.
Recollection	Character level; earned from Memories.
Registry of Births	Every birth record in Meridian; destroyed at the end of Ch1.
Sky Seam	The pink scratch over Meridian that grows every year.
Starfall	A planet overflowing with forgotten memories; also the war begun 100 years ago.
Unwritten, the	Kairos: a person with no birth record.
Vice	An overflowing forgotten memory given monstrous form; leaves a core.
Wall, the	The edge of the mapped world; nothing drawn past it in 80 years.
Wheel of Return	The cycle of filing, living, dying, forgetting and rebirth.

Part 20 · Name changes (v1 to current)

v1 working name	Current
Seren	Sgt. Agnes Calder (internal id: ines)
Elias	Big Boy Bram (Cpl. Bram) (id: bram)
Dr. Sophia Arden	Dr. Naomi Lark (id: noemi), married to Theo Lark
Cyrus Crane	Lucas Crane (id: lucan)
Vigil (crew)	Meridian Garrison
Barnabas, Mother Noa	Removed
The Blotting	The Mercy (rain + fountain + twenty years of drinking)
Lethe springs	The Mercy Fountain
Turning Points / Constellation choices	Removed from the game; replaced by Recollection milestones and Skill Mastery
New	Sister Cassie Vire, Dess Marr, Lyra, Father Ambrose Vane, Sister Agathe, Tessa

APPENDIX A

Chapter 1: the complete script

Generated from the game files. Every cutscene line, every player choice with its responses, conditional lines (with the flag that shows them), mission briefs, party changes, and the walk-around conversations. *Italic grey* = narration. **Gold** = on-screen caption. Green = gameplay. Violet = player choice.

Cold open · The Night the Sky Broke

MERIDIAN. TWENTY YEARS AGO. 11:52 PM.

Woman: The sky! Look at the sky!

Man: Get inside! Everybody get inside!

Garrison soldier: Rift over the Market Ring! Another over the harbor! Another— gods, there's too many of them!

Woman: Where's my son? Has anyone seen my son?!

11:55 PM.

Garrison soldier: Hold the line! Get the families behind the fountain!

Garrison soldier: They're not stopping. Why aren't they stopping?!

Shapes of smoke and ash pour out of the cracks in the sky. Vices. Hundreds of them.

ST. HESPER'S ORPHANAGE. 11:58 PM.

In the middle of the panic, one man is walking. Not running. Walking.

A black cloak. A hood. In his arms, a bundle that doesn't cry.

The man in the black cloak: Almost there. Just a little longer.

The clock above the orphanage gate ticks to 11:59.

And everything stops.

The rain hangs in the air like glass beads. The fire freezes mid-flicker. Every person in Meridian stops mid-scream.

Only the man in the cloak keeps moving.

In the silence there is one sound left. Tick. Tick. Tick. Like a clock inside the stopped minute.

The bundle in his arms squirms. The baby is awake. Its face scrunches up at the ticking, and it starts to cry.

The man in the black cloak: I know. It's loud, isn't it. I'm sorry.

He kneels and sets the baby down on the steps, very gently.

The man in the black cloak: I'm sorry. You'll have to do this part without me.

The man in the black cloak: Don't drink the water.

The man in the black cloak: And this time... finish it.

Then he is gone. Not walking away. Just... gone, like a word rubbed out of a page.

Time starts again. The rifts close one by one before morning. Nobody can say why.

Nun: Oh! Oh, little one. Where did you come from?

Nun: Sister Agathe! A blanket, quickly! There's a baby on the steps!

Above the gate, the clock still reads 11:59. It will never move again.

And nobody in the city remembers a man in a black cloak.

STARFALL: THE ASCENT

STARFALL: THE ASCENT

Chapter 1 · The Minute Meridian Held Its Breath

Scene 1 · Tuesday Errands

TWENTY YEARS LATER. THE MARKET RING.

Kairos (thinking): Tuesday. Three errands, two favors, and if I'm lucky, lunch.

Kairos (thinking): People need things carried, fixed, found. I do it. They pay me in coins, or bread, or a "thank you, dear," which is harder to eat.

Kairos (thinking): And there it is. The Sky Seam. A thin pink scratch over the city. Everyone stopped looking at it years ago.

Kairos (thinking): I didn't. Last spring it was as long as my thumb, held out at arm's length. Today it's my whole hand.

Garrison guard: Staring at the sky again, Kairos?

Kairos: It's bigger.

Garrison guard: It's a scratch. Go do your errands, kid.
Kairos (thinking): Matteo first. He'll have a list. He always has a list.

Gameplay: Tuesday Errands (walk, Market Ring). A normal morning. Talk to the people who need you. Party: Kairos.

Talk: Old Matteo (required)
Old Matteo: Kairos. Good. Read this for me? The ink ran in the rain and my eyes aren't what they were.
Kairos: "Three mackerel for St. Hesper's. Twelve loaves from the baker. Rosa's knee medicine, Thursday. Fence nails, two dozen."
Old Matteo: Thursday. I knew that. I just wanted to hear somebody else say it.
Old Matteo: Twenty years I haven't missed a Sunday cup, and still the Lord lets me lose my glasses.
Kairos: They're on your head.
Old Matteo: …So they are. Go on. I'll pay you this afternoon. Not before. I know you.
(talk again)
Old Matteo: Kairos! Good, you're here. Could you read this for me? The ink ran in the rain—
Kairos: Three mackerel, twelve loaves, Rosa's medicine on Thursday, two dozen nails.
Old Matteo: …Did I already ask you that?
Kairos: It's fine. I like hearing it.
Kairos (thinking): Twice in ten minutes. Last spring it was once a week.

Talk: Fish vendor (required)
(before it opens)
Fish vendor: Fish runner! Got your list yet? Matteo always has a list.
(then)
Fish vendor: Ah, the orphanage's fish runner! How many today?

Puzzle: Errand · The fish stall

□ How many mackerel did Matteo's list say?
Options: Two / **Three** □ / Four
On a miss: That's not what the list said. Kairos never gets the list wrong.
(after solving)
Fish vendor: Three. Mackerel's four coins today.
Kairos: It was three yesterday. And the day before. And it's the same boat.
Fish vendor: Prices change, boy. Wind, tide, my mood.
Kairos: Your mood was fine yesterday. You sold Mrs. Pell two for five and told her it was a special.
Fish vendor: …Three coins. Get out of here before you ruin me.
Fish vendor: And don't tell Father Vane I sell on Sundays. Sundays are for selling, not sipping.

Talk: Baker (required)
(before it opens)
Baker: Morning, Kairos! Bring me Matteo's list first, I'm not guessing again.
(then)
Baker: Tuesday order for St. Hesper's. How many loaves this week? I wrote it down somewhere.

Puzzle: Errand · The bakery

□ How many loaves for St. Hesper's?
Options: Ten / **Twelve** □ / Fourteen
On a miss: No. Twelve? Fourteen? Think about Matteo's list.
(after solving)
Baker: Twelve. Already wrapped. And your roll.
Kairos: Thank you.
Baker: Thirty-two rolls, and that's the first time you said thank you before biting.
Kairos: I'm growing.

Talk: Rosa (required)
(before it opens)
Rosa: There's my sharp boy. Has Matteo found his glasses yet?
(then)
Rosa: Did Matteo tell you when my knee medicine comes? I won't trust it until somebody sensible says it.

Puzzle: Errand · Rosa's medicine

□ When is Rosa's medicine ready?
Options: Wednesday / **Thursday** □ / Friday
On a miss: Not that day. Matteo said it twice.

(after solving)

Rosa: Thursday. Good. He'll read it a third time on Wednesday night, the worrier.
Rosa: You look tired, dear. Are you eating? Proper meals, not just the baker's rolls?
Kairos: Mostly the baker's rolls.
Rosa: Come by Sunday. I'll feed you, and you can fix my shutter.
Kairos: Not going to the chapel?
Rosa: Not since my husband's funeral. The holy water tastes like pennies, and the priests talk too much.

Talk: Garrison guard (optional)

Garrison guard: Morning, Kairos. Rooftop guns got every Vice that fell last night. Not one inside the walls all month.
Kairos: Don't say that out loud.
Garrison guard: Ha! You and that sky.

Talk: Tessa (required, last)

(before it opens)

Tessa: Kairos! Finish your errands, then come help with Mama's flowers!

(then)

Tessa: Kairos! Mama says you remember everything. Is that true?
Kairos: Pretty much.
Tessa: What did I have for breakfast a hundred days ago?
Kairos: You didn't eat breakfast a hundred days ago. You gave your bread to a pigeon and cried when it left.
Tessa: ...That's so embarrassing. Forget it.
Kairos: Can't. Sorry.

9:00 AM.

Flower buckets. Tessa carries the small one and supervises the big one.

Tessa: Kairos. Why do you help everybody all the time?

Player choice · Kairos: Why DO I help everybody?
□ **Honestly? It pays in bread.** (sets c_bread)
Tessa: That's not a real reason.
Kairos: You've never been hungry enough to say that.
□ **Somebody has to remember things for them.** (sets c_earnest)
Tessa: That sounds tiring.
Kairos: It is. But it's less tiring than watching them lose stuff.
□ **Who said I'm helping? I'm collecting favors.** (sets c_joke)
Tessa: For what?
Kairos: One day I'll need a fish, a fence and a free roll at the same time. Then I cash in.
Tessa: That's so dumb.
Kairos: It's a long-term plan.

The clock tower above the square chimes nine. Kairos flinches like someone slammed a door next to his ear.

Tessa: You always do that when the bells go.
Kairos: Just loud.
Kairos (thinking): It isn't the bells. It's the tick under them. Nobody else ever hears it. I stopped telling people when I was seven.

HALF A SECOND OF SOMETHING THAT HASN'T HAPPENED.

Kairos (thinking): —What?
Kairos (thinking): The crane over the fruit stalls. The cable snaps. The beam falls. Tessa looks up. Too late.
Kairos (thinking): Half a second. Then it's gone. The crane is fine.
Kairos (thinking): ...Yet.
Kairos: Tessa. Go find your mom. Right now.
Tessa: Why? You look weird.
Kairos: Please. Just go.
Tessa: Okay, okay...
Kairos (thinking): She walks the wrong way. Toward the crane.

Scene 2 · The Stopped Minute

The cable snaps. Exactly like the vision.

Kairos (thinking): Too far. I'm too far. I'm not going to—

Kairos (thinking): ...

Kairos (thinking): It's quiet.

Kairos (thinking): Tick. Tick. Tick.

Kairos (thinking): The beam is hanging in the air. A pigeon is stuck mid-flap. Nobody is moving. Nobody is breathing.

Kairos: ...Hello?

Kairos (thinking): A light at the end of the street. A clock, made of light, floating at head height. Its two hands are spinning the wrong way.

The Voice: Breathe. You're the only one who can, right now.

Kairos: Did I do this? Who are you?

The Voice: Someone you'll recognize. Not today.

Kairos: That's not an answer.

The Voice: It's the only honest one I have. I'm holding this minute still for you. I can't hold it long.

Kairos (thinking): The clock's two hands pull loose and fly into mine. They grow into blades. Curved, silver-blue, light as paper.

Kairos (thinking): The clock face goes on floating. Blank now. No hands.

The Voice: You hate that sound. I know. I'm sorry.

Kairos: ...It was you. When I was little. Every time the world went quiet.

The Voice: Only when I had to. Every time I hold the minute, the sky tears a little more. So I don't do it often.

The Voice: Today I had to. The girl is still under the beam. Go.

> **Gameplay: Chase the Voice** (frozen, Market Ring · stopped minute). Time has stopped. Follow the light, and push the falling beam away from Tessa. Party: Kairos.

Scene 3 · First Blood

The Voice: You were there.

Kairos: Where? Wait—

Kairos (thinking): It fades. Of course it does.

Snap. Colour and noise slam back into the world. The beam crashes into the stones, a full step away from Tessa.

Tessa: ...Huh? The pole moved.

Kairos (thinking): Everyone in the square drops to their knees, gasping. For them, no time passed. Their lungs still felt a whole minute without air.

Kairos (thinking): And then the Seam opens.

Kairos (thinking): Not a scratch anymore. A wound. Smoke and ash and red-hot eyes crawl out of it.

Kairos: Vices. Inside the walls. In daylight.

Kairos (thinking): The minute. If I could stop it once—

Kairos (thinking): I reach for it. Nothing. Just my own heartbeat, too loud.

Kairos (thinking): So it wasn't me. Or not only me. Fine. Then I do this the slow way.

Kairos (thinking): I've never held a weapon in my life. So why do my feet already know where to stand?

> **Gameplay: First Fight** (fight, Market Ring). Vices pour out of the rift. Your body knows the stance. Party: Kairos.

Kairos (thinking): Breathe. Count. One more.

Kairos (thinking): My hands move like they've done this a thousand times. I hate how easy it is.

A rifle shot cracks from a rooftop. The closest Vice drops.

Sgt. Agnes: Civilian with the swords. Get down or keep fighting. Pick one.

> **Player choice** · Kairos: A soldier on the roof. With a very big rifle.
>
> ▯ **Keep fighting.** (sets c_ines_fight)
>
> **Sgt. Agnes:** Good answer.
>
> ▯ **Can I pick "run away screaming"?** (sets c_ines_joke)
>
> **Sgt. Agnes:** You can. You won't, though. I saw you fight.
>
> ▯ **Who are you?**
>
> **Sgt. Agnes:** The person keeping you alive. Names later.

A huge man in Garrison armour vaults the fruit stall, trips on a crate, and lands shield-first on a Vice. It goes flat.

Big Boy Bram: I'm okay!
Sgt. Agnes: You're always okay, Bram.
Big Boy Bram: Sorry. Sorry, crate.
Kairos: Did he just apologise to a crate?
Sgt. Agnes: He does that. Bram, the families. Swords, you're with me.

Agnes joins the party.

Big Boy Bram joins the party.

Sgt. Agnes: I mark them, you cut them. Bram stands in front of people.
Sgt. Agnes: If one of us is going down, switch in. Don't be a hero about it.
Big Boy Bram: We're a team now! For five minutes. Probably.
Kairos (thinking): A team. I've never been on one of those either.

Gameplay: Garrison (fight, Market Ring). Hold the square with the Garrison until the rift seals. Party: Kairos, Agnes, Big Boy Bram.

Scene 4 · Who Are You?

The rift seals with a sound like a heavy book slamming shut. Smoke. Silence. Fruit everywhere.

Sgt. Agnes: Sergeant Agnes Calder, Meridian Garrison. That's Corporal Bram.
Big Boy Bram: Big Boy Bram. Everybody calls me that. I don't know why.
Sgt. Agnes: You're not army. Where did you learn to fight like that?
Kairos: I didn't. Ten minutes ago I was buying fish.
Sgt. Agnes: People don't learn to fight in ten minutes.
Kairos: I know. That's the part that scares me.
Sgt. Agnes: For somebody who wanted to run away screaming, you stayed pretty well. (if c_ines_joke)
Sgt. Agnes: You told me "keep fighting" before you knew what you were fighting. Bad habit. Useful one. (if c_ines_fight)
Sgt. Agnes: And the blades?
Kairos: You won't believe me.
Sgt. Agnes: Everyone in this square stopped breathing for a minute, and then the sky ripped open. Try me.
Kairos: Everybody stopped. I didn't. A light held the minute for me, and gave me these.
Kairos (thinking): Agnes looks at Bram. Bram looks at Agnes. Neither of them laughs. That's somehow worse.
Big Boy Bram: Uh. Sarge. His shirt is glowing.
Sgt. Agnes: I can see that, Bram.
Kairos (thinking): A mark on my chest. A clock face with no hands. Like the one in the street.
Kairos (thinking): My knees go first. Then the ground comes up very fast.
Big Boy Bram: Got him! …Nope. I didn't. Sorry. Sarge, is he okay?
Sgt. Agnes: He's breathing. St. Lucia's is closest. Pick him up, Corporal. We're going.

Scene 5 · Carry Him

Ash Lane, the road to St. Lucia's Hospital. Small rifts are still opening all over the city.

Big Boy Bram: He's light. Is he supposed to be this light?
Sgt. Agnes: He's an errand boy. They live on bread and favours.
Big Boy Bram: I'd live on bread. Just bread. Forever.
Big Boy Bram: Sarge, are you coming to the Festival this year? My mom saves me a spot in the line.
Sgt. Agnes: I work every Sunday, Bram. On purpose.
Big Boy Bram: …You always say that like it means something.
Sgt. Agnes: Stay behind me. If Vices get close, put him down and let me deal with them.

Gameplay: Carry Him (escort, Ash Lane, toward St. Lucia's). Bram carries Kairos to the hospital. Keep the rifts off him. Switch to Bram to carry him yourself. Party: Agnes, Big Boy Bram.

Scene 6 · St. Lucia's

St. Lucia's Hospital, east ward. Every bed is full. Half the city came in short of breath after the stopped minute.

Dr. Naomi: Pulse normal. Oxygen normal. And "patient was glowing."
She writes it on the inside of her forearm, in small neat letters, under a column of other small neat letters.
Dr. Naomi: By tonight I'll have talked myself out of it. This way I can't.

Sgt. Agnes: He was glowing. Like a lamp.
Dr. Naomi: People don't glow, Sergeant.
Sgt. Agnes: Agreed. Write that down too.
Kairos: The girl. Tessa. Is she okay?
Dr. Naomi: Everyone from your square is fine. I'm Dr. Naomi Lark. What do you remember?
Kairos: All of it. Time stopped. Everybody froze. A light talked to me. I pushed the beam.
Dr. Naomi: Mm. Possibly a concussion.

Player choice · Kairos: Concussion. Right.
□ **I don't have a concussion.**
Dr. Naomi: That's exactly what people with concussions say.
□ **What day is it? …Kidding. It's Tuesday.** (sets c_noemi_joke)
Dr. Naomi: Funny. I'm still writing "possible concussion."
Big Boy Bram: I liked it.
□ **I remember your shoes are untied.** (sets c_noemi_sharp)
Dr. Naomi: …They are.
Dr. Naomi: Fine. Your memory works. That doesn't mean the rest of you does.

The door bangs open. A man with wild hair and a beeping brass box rushes in.
Theo: He doesn't have a concussion!
Dr. Naomi: Theo. Visitors aren't allowed in the ward.
Theo: I'm your husband, I'm allowed everywhere. Hi. Theo. I build things. Hold this.
He pushes the box into Kairos's hands. Three needles twitch on its face.
Theo: Every clock I own lost sixty seconds this morning. Every clock in the city. I want to know where the minute went missing first. Read it with me.

Puzzle: Theo's reader · Find the lost minute

□ Three districts lost a minute at 9:04. Which lost it first? _Garrison Yard: 9:04:03. The harbour: 9:04:05. The Market Ring: 9:04:00._
Options: Garrison Yard / The harbour / **The Market Ring** □
On success: Theo: The Market Ring. Of course it is.
On a miss: Theo: Look at the seconds. Smallest number wins.
□ Inside the Market Ring, which clock stopped first? _The tower clock: 9:04:00.4. The crane gauge over the fruit stalls: 9:04:00.0. The baker's timer: 9:04:00.7._
Options: The tower clock / **The crane gauge** □ / The baker's timer
On success: Kairos: That's where I was standing.
On a miss: Theo: Closer. Tenths of a second, assistant.
□ Theo sweeps the box around the ward. Where do the needles jump highest?
Options: At the window, toward the Seam / **Over Kairos's chest** □ / Near Theo's bag of turrets
On a miss: Theo: Not there. Keep moving it.

All three needles pin against the glass. Right over the clock-shaped mark on his chest.
Theo: The exact centre was you.
Kairos: …You believe me?
Theo: I've been waiting six years for something weird enough to prove I'm not crazy.
Theo: One more thing. The Seam on my scope grew a hand's width at 9:04. Right when the minute went missing.
Kairos (thinking): "Every time I hold the minute, the sky tears a little more." I didn't think it meant a hand's width.
Theo: What?
Kairos: Nothing. Later.
Kairos: Three rifts in one day. That's never happened, right?
Sgt. Agnes: Not inside the walls. Not in my lifetime.
Theo: She skips the Festival every year. I go for the fried dough.
Dr. Naomi: He doesn't drink anything there. I check.
Kairos: Why?
Dr. Naomi: Habit.
Every light in the ward flickers at once.
Theo: That's not the power. My reader's spiking. Something is tearing open inside the building.
Dr. Naomi: The far beds. Thirty patients who can barely breathe. They can't run.

Sgt. Agnes: Then nothing reaches them.
Dr. Naomi: I'm coming. I can keep people standing while they fight.
Theo: And I have turrets in my bag. Please don't ask why I carry turrets in my bag.

Naomi joins the party.

Theo joins the party.

Gameplay: St. Lucia's (defense, St. Lucia's · east ward). Hold the ward. Do not let the Vices reach the patients' beds.

Choose 3 · "Defend St. Lucia's": Five of you now. Only three fit between the beds. The others guard the stairs.

The rift closes. Every patient is still in their bed.
Dr. Naomi: You enjoyed that.
Theo: Parts of it.
Dr. Naomi: Me too. Don't tell anyone.

Gameplay: Ward Rounds (walk, St. Lucia's · east ward). Evening at St. Lucia's. Ask the patients by the window their birthdays, or just tell Naomi you're done. Party: Kairos.

Talk: Patient (optional)
Kairos: Dr. Lark wants to know your birthday.
patient: Spring. It was spring. I had the day a minute ago.
patient: My wife will know. She does my dates.

Talk: Patient (optional)
Kairos: When's your birthday?
patient: The fourteenth of… no.
patient: Isn't that funny. I go every Sunday. I never miss.
Kairos (thinking): She laughs. It isn't funny to her either.

Talk: Dockworker (optional)
Kairos: When's your birthday?
dock: Ninth of Leo. Hour of the noon bell, my mam always said.
dock: Don't make it Sunday cups, me. Fish don't wait.

Talk: Theo (optional)
Theo: Don't touch the box.
Theo: …Okay, touch the box. See that needle? It hasn't settled since 9:04.
Theo: Something is still open somewhere. I just don't know where.

Talk: Big Boy Bram (optional)
Big Boy Bram: I gave my bread to the man in bed four. He forgot he already ate.
Big Boy Bram: So I gave him more bread.

Talk: Naomi (required)
Dr. Naomi: Done already?
Kairos: I didn't ask everyone.
Dr. Naomi: Then ask tomorrow. Some days half of them can't tell me their own birthday.
Kairos: Stress?
Dr. Naomi: That's the official answer.
Dr. Naomi: Go sleep. That's a prescription.
(variant, if Kairos asked at least two patients)
Dr. Naomi: Well?
Kairos: Two of three couldn't tell me.
Dr. Naomi: Last spring it was one in ten.
She writes something on her arm, under "patient was glowing." She doesn't show him what.
Dr. Naomi: Go sleep. That's a prescription.
Theo: We have to report this. The Concord Office keeps every record in Meridian. Every clock, every birth.
Sgt. Agnes: And they'll want to see him.
Kairos: Is that bad?
Sgt. Agnes: I don't know yet. That's why I'm coming.
Theo: Also. You need a job? I need an assistant who remembers where I put things. You found the minute faster than I did.

Kairos: ...Does it pay?
Theo: In money. Mostly real.
Kairos: I told a kid this morning I help people for bread. This is a promotion. (if c_bread)
Dr. Naomi: Tessa's mother came through the ward. She says you told her girl somebody has to remember things for everyone. (if c_earnest)
Dr. Naomi: That's a heavy job to give yourself. (if c_earnest)
Kairos: Somebody has to. (if c_earnest)
Dr. Naomi: Tomorrow. Everyone sleeps first.

Scene 7 · The Concord Office

THE NEXT MORNING. THE CONCORD OFFICE.
Kairos (thinking): Marble floors. Cabinets up to the ceiling. The whole city on paper.
Theo: We report the event, register you as a witness, then breakfast. In and out.
Kairos (thinking): The queue goes around the hall twice.

Gameplay: The Queue (walk, Concord Office). Take a number. Everyone in Meridian ends up in this line eventually. Party: Kairos, Theo.

Talk: Engaged (optional)
fiance: Our charts say Scorpio and Leo. The clerk calls it a "difficult aspect."
fiance: We've been engaged six years. We're appealing. Again.
Kairos (thinking): Six years of standing in this line to ask paper for permission.

Talk: Mother (optional)
qmother: They put him in the masons' school. Fourth House, they said. Builders and foundations.
boy: I want to draw ships.
qmother: Hush.
boy: I draw them anyway.

Talk: Widow (optional)
widow: My husband's record says he died in the First Starfall.
widow: He died last winter. In our bed. I held his hand.
widow: They won't change it. The record is older than my memory, they say.
Kairos (thinking): If the paper says it, it happened. That's the rule here.

Talk: Records clerk (optional)
rclerk: Every child in Meridian is registered within the hour. Hour, minute, stars, Houses.
rclerk: Your record decides your school, your trade, who you may marry.
rclerk: It's the one thing this city agrees on, young man. Take a number.

Talk: Theo (optional)
Theo: Paper is the only thing this city trusts.
Theo: Which is why I'm about to hand them a witness statement about a stopped minute. This will go great.

Talk: Window 3 (required)
Clerk: Number forty-one. Name.
Kairos: Kairos.
Clerk: Surname.
Kairos: Don't have one. I grew up at St. Hesper's.
Clerk: Then I'll pull your record.
Kairos (thinking): Every child, within the hour. Nobody ever showed me mine.
A young man in a sharp grey coat takes the folder from the clerk without asking.
Clerk: Mr. Crane.
Lucas: Lucas Crane, senior clerk. Yes, that Crane. You can stop staring.
He opens the folder. Reads it. His face doesn't move.
Lucas: It's blank. No hour. No stars. No Houses. Just a name, in pencil.
Lucas: Congratulations. You don't exist.
Kairos (thinking): The couple in the queue had six years of appeals. The widow had the wrong death. I don't even have a wrong one.
Kairos (thinking): And then I look at the man holding my blank page.

Kairos (thinking): Taller. Colder. The same crooked eyebrow when he reads.
Kairos: Lucas? It's me.
Lucas: Do I know you?

- **Player choice** · Kairos: He really doesn't remember me.
- **We shared a room for nine years.** (sets c_truth)
- **Lucas:** Everyone in this building has a story about knowing the Chancellor's son.
- **Kairos:** You used to steal bread and blame the cat.
- **Lucas:** How charming.
- **Kairos:** There wasn't a cat.
- **...No. Sorry. Wrong person.** (sets c_lie)
- **Lucas:** Clearly.
- **Kairos (thinking):** It hurts more to say it than I thought it would.

Lucas: What happened to your hands?
Kairos: A kitchen fire. A long time ago. I pulled someone out.
Lucas: How heroic. Next.
Kairos (thinking): But his hand on the folder tightens. Just a little.
Footsteps. Two guards, and a smiling man in a white coat with reading glasses on a chain.
Dr. Ezekiel Marr: So this is our Unwritten. The Registry's little blank page.
Dr. Ezekiel Marr: Dr. Ezekiel Marr. I study Vices for the Chancellor. As of nine o'clock yesterday morning, I study you.
Theo: Dr. Marr, we came to report the event, not to—
Dr. Ezekiel Marr: And I'm so grateful you did, Mr. Lark. It saves everyone so much time.
Kairos: And if I say no?
Dr. Ezekiel Marr: You won't. You're a helpful boy. Everyone in the Market Ring says so.
Dr. Ezekiel Marr: Besides, you already agreed. Didn't you? You came here on your own.
The guards step forward. Bram moves to stop them. Agnes grabs his arm.
Sgt. Agnes: Not here. We fight Council guards in the Council's building, we all go to a cell, and nobody gets him out.
Big Boy Bram: But Sarge—
Sgt. Agnes: I know, Bram.
Kairos: It's fine. I'll be fine.
Kairos (thinking): I'm lying. I think everyone knows.
Kairos (thinking): At the door I look back at Lucas. He's looking at the floor.

Scene 8 · This Won't Hurt

THE INSTITUTE. THIRD SUB-LEVEL.
Kairos (thinking): White tiles. Glass tanks full of smoky crystals. And a clock on the wall. Of course there's a clock.
Dr. Ezekiel Marr: You keep looking at that. Your heart rate jumps every time it ticks.
Kairos: Could you take it down?
Dr. Ezekiel Marr: No. Dess, the needle.
A young woman at the console doesn't look up. Her pen is moving down a column of numbers faster than anyone could read them.
Dess: His heart rate is one-forty. If we go in now the reading's useless, it'll be all adrenaline—
Dr. Ezekiel Marr: In the lab you speak when the numbers are interesting, Dess.
Dess: ...These are interesting.
Kairos (thinking): He doesn't answer that. She doesn't take it back.
Dr. Ezekiel Marr: Relax. This won't hurt.
Kairos: It hurts.
Dr. Ezekiel Marr: No, it doesn't. You think it does. That's just stress. Breathe for me.

- **Player choice** · Kairos: A man smiling while he hurts you.
- **Then you go first.** (sets c_marr_joke)
- **Dr. Ezekiel Marr:** Ha! Oh, I like you. That will make this so much more unpleasant.
- **...Okay.** (sets c_marr_comply)
- **Dr. Ezekiel Marr:** Good boy. See? Much easier when we agree.
- **(Say nothing. Stare at the clock.)** (sets c_marr_silent)
- **Dr. Ezekiel Marr:** The silent ones always break the loudest. Did you know that?

Dr. Ezekiel Marr: You signed the consent form at the Concord Office, by the way. You remember.
Kairos: I didn't sign anything.
Dr. Ezekiel Marr: You did. You just don't remember. That happens to everyone in this city. Even you, apparently.
Kairos (thinking): I remember everything. I didn't sign.
Kairos (thinking): ...Did I?
Kairos (thinking): That's his trick. He doesn't need the needle. He makes you doubt your own head.
Dr. Ezekiel Marr: Dess. A core.
She brings one: a fist-sized smoky crystal. What a Vice leaves behind when it dies. Marr presses it into Kairos's strapped hand.
The core lights up. And sings.
A little girl laughing. Then a woman's voice, tired and kind: "Come inside, little star. Your father's home."
Dess: ...
Dess: My mother called me that.
Dr. Ezekiel Marr: Every mother in Meridian says "little star," Dess. Put it back on the shelf.
Dess: The resonance doubles every time the clock ticks. No— it isn't the clock. It's syncing to his pulse.
Dr. Ezekiel Marr: There. Now the numbers are interesting.
Dr. Ezekiel Marr: Do you know what's on those shelves, Dess? Everything this city forgot. Every one of them was somebody's.
Dr. Ezekiel Marr: If a core can say it once, I can make it say it again. Imagine giving it back to them.
Dess: And if they don't want it back?
Dr. Ezekiel Marr: Then they never have to know it was gone.
Kairos (thinking): He took the core away from her very fast. Faster than he does anything else.
Kairos (thinking): She watched which shelf he put it on.

Scene 9 · There Wasn't a Cat

THAT EVENING. LUCAS WALKS HOME THE LONG WAY.
Lucas: "There wasn't a cat." (if c_truth)
Lucas: "Wrong person." He was lying. Why would a stranger lie about that? (if c_lie)
Lucas: Home is east. I'm walking north.
Lucas: I've never been to St. Hesper's in my life. I know every turn.

> **Gameplay: The Long Way Home** (walk, St. Hesper's, after dark). Lucas walks home the long way. Something keeps pulling him toward the orphanage. Party: Lucas.

Examine: bread (required)
The bakery next door is closing. Warm bread, the end of a loaf in the window.
Lucas: Somebody always stole the end piece.
Lucas: ...I did. I stole the end piece. And someone covered for me.

Examine: window (required)
The kitchen window of St. Hesper's. The frame is new. The stone above it is still black.
Lucas: I've never been inside this building.
Lucas: So why do I know the door sticks?

Examine: step (required)
A chipped saucer of milk on the back step.
Lucas: There isn't a cat.
Lucas: ...Why do I know that?

Examine: The Moon Gate (required, last)
(before it opens)
The orphanage gate. Not yet. Something else first.
(then)
The clock above the gate. 11:59. It has said 11:59 his whole life.
He has never looked at it before. He has looked at it a thousand times.

ELEVEN YEARS AGO. THE NIGHT BEFORE ADOPTION DAY.
Lucas (age 9): If Sister Agathe catches us, we say the cat did it.
Kairos (age 9): There isn't a cat.

Lucas (age 9): Then she can't prove it wasn't the cat.
Kairos (age 9): That's the worst plan I've ever heard.
Lucas (age 9): You say that about all my plans.
Kairos (age 9): Because I remember all of them.
A lamp tips over. The kitchen curtains catch.
Lucas (age 9): Kairos— the door's stuck— I can't—
Kairos (age 9): Lucas! Lucas, hold on—
And the fire stops.
The flames hang still like paper cutouts. The smoke stops in the air. Only one boy is still moving.
Kairos (age 9): That sound again… tick, tick, tick. Not now. Please, not now.
Kairos (age 9): …Okay. Whatever this is, it's helping. Lucas, give me your hand. Don't let go.

THE NEXT MORNING.
Sister Agathe: He pulled the other boy out through the fire, Chancellor. His hands are badly burned. He has a fever.
Chancellor Augustin Crane: I came for the boy who counts. The one with the memory.
Sister Agathe: He may not recover for weeks. And the other boy keeps saying the fire stopped. Smoke does strange things to children.
Chancellor Augustin Crane: And the Vices on your roof last night?
Sister Agathe: The first in years. We don't know why they came.
Chancellor Augustin Crane: I don't have weeks.
Chancellor Augustin Crane: Give me the other one.
Lucas (age 9): But I— Kairos is—
Chancellor Augustin Crane: You'll forget him soon enough. The Church will see to that.
Lucas: The fire stopped. Everything stopped, and he was the only one moving.
Lucas: He burned his hands for me. And today I asked him if I knew him.
Lucas: That night the Church gave me a silver cup. "So the new life can begin clean." I slept for two days.
Lucas: When I woke up he was just… gone. I thought that's what growing up felt like.

THE CRANE HOUSE.
The Chancellor's study. Midnight. One lamp.
Lucas: You went to St. Hesper's for a boy who counted.
Chancellor Augustin Crane: I went for an heir.
Lucas: You went for him. He was sick, so you took me.
Chancellor Augustin Crane: I took the child who could leave that day. That is what adoption is, Lucas.
Lucas: And the cup?
Chancellor Augustin Crane: You cried for a month. The Church offered mercy. I accepted it on your behalf. I would do it again.
Lucas: He burned his hands for me.
Chancellor Augustin Crane: And I gave you everything else. The name. The house. The desk you are so good at. Everything you have, I gave you.
Lucas: I know.
Chancellor Augustin Crane: Then go to bed. Tomorrow you'll feel differently.
There is a silver cup on the shelf behind the desk. Lucas has walked past it every day for eleven years.
He doesn't answer. He takes his coat.

THE SAME NIGHT. A GARRISON SAFEHOUSE.
Big Boy Bram: We just let them take him. We stood there.
Sgt. Agnes: We let them take him so we'd still be free to get him back.
Theo: The Institute is a fortress. We don't even know which floor.
Dr. Naomi: Someone in that building knows.
A knock at the door. Everyone freezes.
Lucas: Third sub-level. The guards change shifts at eleven. That's your gap.
Sgt. Agnes: You're the Chancellor's son. This afternoon you said "next."
Lucas: This afternoon I didn't remember a kitchen fire.
Dr. Naomi: And now you do. All of it?
Lucas: Pieces. A boy with burned hands. Bread. A cat that didn't exist.

Lucas: A few hours of memories against eleven years of being someone else. I don't know which one is lying.
Dr. Naomi: So why are you here?
Lucas: Because I want to find out which one is me. I can't do that if Marr takes him apart first.
Sgt. Agnes: Good enough.
Big Boy Bram: ...I'm going to hug you.
Lucas: Please don't.
Big Boy Bram: Later, then.

Lucas joins the party.

Sgt. Agnes: Three of us push down the stairs. The rest hold the door behind us.
Lucas: I know the layout. Follow me, and don't touch the tanks.
Theo: What's in the tanks?
Lucas: Nothing you want on your hands.

Gameplay: Breakout · Outside (fight, Institute sub-levels). Fight down through the Institute. Third sub-level.

Choose 3 · "Breakout · outside team": Kairos is locked inside. Pick three to fight down through the sub-levels.

Kairos (thinking): Alarms. Upstairs. Someone's coming.
Kairos (thinking): The minute. How did it feel? Like holding your breath. Like grabbing the second hand.
Kairos (thinking): I reach for it. Nothing. Again. Nothing.
Kairos (thinking): Then, behind the clock on the wall, something I can't see pulls the second hand back. Gently. Like it's helping me with a heavy door.
Kairos (thinking): Three seconds. Only three. Enough to slip a strap.
Kairos: That wasn't me. Someone's holding it with me.
Kairos (thinking): I don't know who. I'll say thank you later.
Kairos (thinking): Guards and cameras in every hall. Stop time, walk through their sight lines. Don't get greedy.

Gameplay: Breakout (stealth, Institute sub-level). Slip past the guards and cameras. Stop time to walk through their sight lines. Party: Kairos.

A sealed steel door. Kairos from one side, the others from the stairs. And Dess, already there, holding her father's key card.

Kairos: Lucas?
Lucas: I remembered. Some of it. The bread. The fire. Your hands.
Lucas: I don't know who I am to you yet.
Kairos: You don't have to know tonight.
Lucas: Later, then. We move.
Dess: He's going to know it was me.
Kairos: Then why are you helping?
Dess: Because that core called me "little star." And when I told him, he only asked if he could make it say it again.
Dess: And you told him to go first. Nobody talks to him like that. I almost laughed. (if c_marr_joke)
Dess: You said "okay" to him. Everyone does. He makes it the easiest word in the room. (if c_marr_comply)
Dess: You never said a word to him. He wrote "subject uncooperative" three times. (if c_marr_silent)
Kairos: Good. (if c_marr_silent)
Dess: I'm taking the cores. Not all of them. The ones with people in them. Help me listen.

Puzzle: Dess's cores · Which ones are people?

□ Dess holds a core to her ear, then yours. What do you hear? _A hum. Steady. The same pitch as the lamps in this room._
Options: Someone's lullaby / **The lab's generator, soaked into the glass** □ / A heartbeat
On success: Dess: Empty. Leave it.
On a miss: Dess: Listen again. It's the same note as the lamps.
□ The next one. _A man counting coins, losing count, and laughing at himself._
Options: **A person. Take it.** □ / Interference. Leave it.
On success: Dess: Somebody's Tuesday. We take it.
On a miss: Dess: Machines don't laugh at themselves.
□ The last shelf. Marr's shelf. A core sits in the slot where he put "little star". _Dess taps it. Nothing. Not a hum, not a voice. Just cold glass._
Options: That's her mother's core / **It's a blank. Someone swapped it** □
On a miss: Dess: Listen. There's nothing in there.

Dess: It's a blank. I swapped them this afternoon, while he was writing about you.
Dess: He's been running tests on an empty crystal for six hours.
Kairos: Dess.
Dess: Don't. If I think about it I'll put it back.
She opens her hand. The real core is in it. A small blue figure of light rises out: a little girl, who waves at Dess and floats at her side.
Dess: Hi. Will you help us get out?
Kairos (thinking): The girl of light has a freckle under her left eye.
Kairos (thinking): So does Dess.

Dess joins the party.

Gameplay: Escape (fight, Institute sub-levels). Get out. All of you.

Choose 3 · "Escape": Dess must go: her spirits are new. Try switching Lucas to Kairos.

Lucas: I'm sorry.
Kairos: For what?
Lucas: For forgetting. For looking at the floor.
Kairos: You came back. That counts.
Lucas: I came back for a boy I've remembered for six hours. You had me for nine years, and then nothing.
Kairos: I had errands. It was fine.
Lucas: It wasn't fine.
Kairos: ...No.
Lucas: Then I'm going to be very annoying about catching up.

Scene 10 · The Inquisitor

Church bells all over the city. On the rooftops of Ash Lane, a figure in grey and red blocks the way, swinging a chained censer that drips fire.

Sister Cassie: Sister Cassie Vire, Office of Correction. The Unwritten comes with me. The rest of you go home.

Player choice · Kairos: An Inquisitor. Great.
I have a name. It's Kairos. (sets c_cass_name)
Sister Cassie: Not according to the Registry.
Do I get a say in this?
Sister Cassie: No. That's rather the point of the Office.
Can I at least finish my bread first? (sets c_cass_joke)
Sister Cassie: ...You don't have any bread.
Kairos: Then this is already a terrible night.
Big Boy Bram: Ha!
Sister Cassie: Do not laugh, Corporal.

Sister Cassie: A person with no birth record has no stars. A person with no stars was never meant to exist. The Church corrects mistakes.
Sgt. Agnes: Generous of you, letting the rest of us go.
Sister Cassie: It isn't an offer, Sergeant.

Gameplay: The Inquisitor (fight, Ash Lane rooftops). Sister Cassie punishes standing still. Keep moving.

Choose 3 · "The Inquisitor": Sister Cassie punishes standing still. Keep moving.

Father Ambrose Vane: Sister. The building beneath them is a lodging house.
Sister Cassie: Yes, Father.
Father Ambrose Vane: Burn it. If they won't come down, bring the roof down with them.
Sister Cassie: Father, there are families inside.
Father Ambrose Vane: Faithful people. They will be forgiven.
Cassie hesitates. Too long. Vane sighs, and throws the flask himself.
Kairos: No— no, no, no!
Kairos (thinking): The minute. I can't do this one alone. I know that now.
Kairos: Please. Whoever you are. Hold it for me.
Kairos (thinking): Something answers. The fire stops mid-lick. Twenty seconds. Maybe.
Kairos (thinking): Above the roofs the Seam twitches, like a cut pulled open by a thumb.

Gameplay: The Frozen Fire (frozen, Ash Lane lodging house). Time is stopped for 20 seconds. Carry three people out of the fire. Party: Kairos.

Time snaps back.

Kairos (thinking): Everyone's out. Coughing, crying, alive. All of them.

Sister Cassie: You had a clear way out. You went into the fire instead.

Kairos: You didn't throw that flask. You hesitated.

Sister Cassie: Hesitation is a sin, in my Office.

Kairos: Then your Office is wrong about something.

Sister Cassie: ...Go. Before I remember my orders.

She doesn't leave. Not right away. She stands on the cobbles and counts the families, twice, until Father Vane says her name a second time.

Scene 11 · The Clock Tower

THE CLOCK TOWER OF ST. HESPER'S.

Lucas: The old clock tower over St. Hesper's. We used to hide up here. Nobody climbs it anymore.

Kairos (thinking): Same dead clock. Still 11:59. I used to think it was waiting for me.

Bram makes toast over a lantern. Theo takes a drone apart on his knees. Naomi works her way round the room with a tin of salve.

Theo: Okay. I need to say this out loud or I'll explode.

Theo: You stopped time, a floating clock gave you swords, and now the sky is angry about it.

Player choice · Kairos: That's... a lot, said out loud.

- **When you say it like that it sounds bad.**
  - **Theo:** I was going for interesting. Bad is a bonus.
  - **Dr. Naomi:** Theo.
- **Honestly I just want breakfast.** (sets c_breakfast)
  - **Big Boy Bram:** I have toast!
  - **Kairos:** Bram. You're my favourite person.
  - **Theo:** Hey!
- **You forgot "and he has a job now."** (sets c_job)
  - **Theo:** Mostly-real-money job. Yes. Welcome aboard, assistant.
  - **Dr. Naomi:** Oh no. There are two of them now.

Kairos: Agnes. At the hospital you said "not inside the walls." What about outside?

Sgt. Agnes: Outside, it happened all the time. That's why there's nothing out there anymore.

Theo: Meridian is the last free city on Aster. Everything past the Wall fell before any of us were born.

Kairos: I've read every map in the orphanage library. Twice. They all stop at the same line.

Sgt. Agnes: Then you know as much as the Council does. Tomorrow we figure out what's next. Tonight everyone sleeps.

Big Boy Bram: Wait. Kairos. Tessa told her mom you collect favours. Do I owe you one? (if c_joke)

Kairos: Three. One for the crate, one for carrying me, one for the toast. (if c_joke)

Big Boy Bram: That's fair. (if c_joke)

Sgt. Agnes: Kairos. Go talk to people. You look like you need it.

Gameplay: The Clock Tower (walk, St. Hesper's clock tower). Evening. Nobody is chasing you for once. Talk to whoever you like. Lucas is at the clock face. Party: Kairos.

Talk: Lucas (required) · raises Bond: Lucas

Lucas: You'd make me count the seconds up here, so we knew when inspection was over.

Kairos: You made ME count. I hated it.

Lucas: You did it anyway.

Kairos: Because you asked.

Lucas: The kitchen fire. It stopped, didn't it. I didn't dream that.

Kairos: It stopped. I heard the ticking, and I pulled you out. I still don't know why I could.

Lucas: My father says I'll feel differently tomorrow.

Kairos: Will you?

Lucas: I keep waiting to feel like the boy who stole bread. I don't. I feel like a clerk who's very good at forms.

Kairos: You don't have to be him.

Lucas: No. I don't think I need to be who I was.

Lucas: I just need to be someone who doesn't leave.
Lucas: So. Whatever comes out of those rifts. The Church. My father. I'm not losing you twice.
Kairos: That sounds like a vow.
Lucas: It is one. Don't make it weird.

Talk: Agnes (optional) · raises Bond: Agnes
Kairos: What are you writing?
Sgt. Agnes: Incident report. The Garrison wants one for every rift.
Sgt. Agnes: You remember everything. Check my times.

Puzzle: Agnes's report · Tuesday, in order (optional, can leave)

□ What happened first?
Options: The rift opened / **The crane cable snapped** □ / Kairos's shirt started glowing
On a miss: Agnes: That came later. Think.
□ And then?
Options: **The rift opened over the square** □ / Kairos fainted
On a miss: Agnes: Not yet. You were still standing.

(after solving)
Kairos: You left my name out.
Sgt. Agnes: Paperwork is how they find people.
Sgt. Agnes: Crane failure. Rift. Civilian assisted. Civilian unnamed.
Kairos: Thanks.
Sgt. Agnes: Don't. It's just correct paperwork.

Talk: Bram (optional) · raises Bond: Big Boy Bram
Big Boy Bram: Toast?
Kairos: Please.
Big Boy Bram: Sarge lets me carry the heavy things. She says it's because I'm strong.
Big Boy Bram: It's because she hates carrying things.
Sgt. Agnes: I heard that. _()_
Big Boy Bram: Love you, Sarge.
Big Boy Bram: My mom never misses a Sunday. Last week she called me Tomas. That's my brother.
Kairos: ...Does it hurt?
Big Boy Bram: She's just tired. Everybody's tired.
He burns the next piece of toast and eats it himself without saying anything.

Talk: Theo (optional) · raises Bond: Theo
Theo: Assistant! Perfect timing. Hold this. No, that. Hand me the— the thing.

Puzzle: Theo's drone · Hand me the thing (optional, can leave)

□ Theo holds his hand out without looking. "The thing. With the spring."
Options: **The coiled spring** □ / The brass lens / A spoon
On a miss: Theo: That's not a spring. That's... why do I have that?
□ "Now the other thing." He mimes something small and round you look through.
Options: **The brass lens** □ / Another spoon / His sandwich
On a miss: Theo: Round and you look THROUGH it.

(after solving)
Theo: You hand me the right thing before I know what I want. Do you know how rare that is?
Dr. Naomi: I do.
Theo: ...Naomi does that too.
Theo: Where's my—
Dr. Naomi: Left pocket.
Theo: Thank you.

Talk: Naomi (optional) · raises Bond: Naomi
Dr. Naomi: Hand.
She turns his palm to the lantern. The old burn scars, pale and shiny.
Dr. Naomi: How old were you?
Kairos: Nine.

Dr. Naomi: You remember the pain?
Kairos: I remember everything.
Dr. Naomi: That's not the same as being fine.
Kairos: Why do you really write on your arm?
Dr. Naomi: Because people in this city talk themselves out of the scary things. I don't want to be one of them.
Dr. Naomi: You made a concussion joke to the doctor checking you for a concussion. Bold. (if c_noemi_joke)
Dr. Naomi: You noticed my shoes. Nobody notices my shoes. (if c_noemi_sharp)
Dr. Naomi: If this gets worse, and it will, I'm not leaving him behind. Or you. That isn't kindness. I'm just stubborn.

Talk: Dess (optional) · raises Bond: Dess
Kairos: You left your father tonight. Are you okay?
Dess: Ask me tomorrow. Or n-next year.
She has the cores lined up by colour, then by size, then by colour again.
Dess: I can hear them a little. Somebody's bad day. A song. Rain on a roof I've never seen.
Dess: The little one who helped us. She has my laugh. I've been trying not to think about why.
Kairos: Dess…
Dess: Don't. Please. I'm smart enough to guess. I'm not brave enough to know. Not yet.

Examine: The clock (required, last)
(before it opens)
Kairos (thinking): The dead clock. Later. Lucas is still up there by the face.
(then)
Kairos (thinking): I put my hand on the dead clock.
Kairos (thinking): Some mornings I wake up with my hand already reaching for something. Like I put it down yesterday.
Kairos (thinking): Now I know the shape of it. A pen. A man's hand, writing by candlelight. My handwriting. But older.
Kairos (thinking): A voice. Mine. "And this time, finish it."
Kairos (thinking): Finish what?
Kairos (thinking): Everyone's asleep. Except me. And the girl sitting on the beam above us.
Lyra: Go back to sleep.
Kairos: Who are you?
Lyra: Someone who's supposed to be watching. Not talking.
Kairos: You're bad at it.
Lyra: …Tomorrow is the Festival of the Mercy. They hand out cups of water to everyone. Don't drink anything they give you.
Kairos: Someone else told me that once.
Lyra: Then you should've listened the first time.
Kairos (thinking): She drops out the window. Gone.
Kairos (thinking): Sister Agathe gave every orphan a spoon of that water on Sundays. The others always looked so peaceful after.
Kairos (thinking): I never felt anything. I figured God skipped me. He skips me a lot.

Scene 12 · Festival of the Mercy

THE NEXT DAY. FESTIVAL SQUARE.
Kairos (thinking): Banners. Music. Fried dough. The whole city in one square.
Kairos (thinking): After the week we had, it's almost too much. Everyone's laughing.
Priest: Drink, and be forgiven. Drink, and let it go.
Priest: Twenty years ago Heaven wept on this city, and this fountain rose out of the stones. The Church keeps it. The Church shares it.

Gameplay: Festival of the Mercy (walk, Festival Square). The whole city in one square. Banners, fried dough, and a line for the fountain that goes around twice. Party: Kairos.

Talk: Theo (optional)
Theo: Fried dough. Don't tell Naomi.
Dr. Naomi: I can see you, Theo.
Theo: She'll check I didn't drink anything. I didn't drink anything.
Dr. Naomi: I know. I checked.

Talk: Bram (optional)

Big Boy Bram: My mom's in the cup line. I promised her sweet bread from the baker's stall.

Big Boy Bram: Could you get it? If I leave the line she'll forget where I went.

Kairos (thinking): He says it like a joke. It isn't one.

(talk again)

Big Boy Bram: The baker's stall is the one with the striped roof!

Talk: Baker's stall (optional)

(before it opens)

Baker: Kairos! Sweet bread's for customers with a reason. Find yourself one.

(then)

Baker: Sweet bread for Bram's mother? On the house. She's been coming to this stall for thirty years.

Baker: She used to know my name.

Talk: Bram's mother (optional) · raises Bond: Big Boy Bram

(before it opens)

bmom: Hello, dear. Are you a friend of my boy's?

(then)

Kairos: From Bram. Sweet bread.

bmom: Oh, bless you. Tomas, say thank you to your friend.

Big Boy Bram: Thank you.

Bram doesn't correct her. He holds her bag while she waits, and fixes her scarf when the wind takes it.

Big Boy Bram: She made me a quilt every year I was in the Garrison. I still have all of them.

Big Boy Bram: She remembers the quilts. That's enough. Most days.

Talk: Rosa (optional)

Rosa: Not drinking, are you, dear?

Kairos: Someone told me not to.

Rosa: Smart someone. Tastes like pennies.

Talk: In the line (optional)

believer: My husband's gone two years. Most nights I can't sleep for missing him.

believer: After the cup, I sleep. Is that so wrong?

Kairos (thinking): I don't have an answer for her. I don't think there is a good one.

Talk: Lanterns (optional)

lantern: Star lanterns! One for every sign. Find your own and the next one's free.

Puzzle: Lantern stall · Find the right sign (optional, can leave)

□ Tessa wants the lantern with her sign. She was born in high summer, under the Crab.

Options: **Cancer** □ / Leo / Aries

On a miss: Lantern seller: The Crab, love. Not that one.

□ Then one for Kairos. The seller asks your sign.

Options: Pisces / **"I don't have one."** □

On success: Lantern seller: Everybody has one, love. …Here. Take a blank one. Write your own on it.

(after solving)

The blank lantern is plain paper. Kairos holds it a long time before he lights it.

Talk: Sister Cassie (required)

Sister Cassie: Unwritten.

Kairos: Kairos.

Sister Cassie: …Kairos. You wrote it on that roof. I remember. (if c_cass_name)

Sister Cassie: You shouldn't be here. Father Vane is ten steps away.

Kairos: You're handing out cups?

Sister Cassie: I keep order in the line. People come here carrying things they can't put down. They leave lighter.

Kairos: And the things?

Sister Cassie: God keeps them.

Sister Cassie: I believe that. I have to. I've believed it since I was six.

Talk: Tessa (required, last)

(before it opens)

Tessa: Kairos! Go see the fountain first. Mama's still in line.
(then)
Tessa: Kairos! Mama's almost at the front.
Tessa: She's been crying all week. Since the minute when nobody could breathe.
A mother in black reaches the front of the line, eyes red. Tessa holds onto her skirt.
Priest: Drink, and be forgiven.
She drinks. A moment later she is smiling, calm, like someone set down a heavy bag.
Tessa's mother: ...Oh. I feel lighter. Tessa, why was I crying?
Tessa: Because of the minute, Mama. When you couldn't breathe.
Tessa's mother: Did I? Well. It doesn't matter now.
Kairos (thinking): She looks happy. She also looks empty.
Kairos (thinking): Tessa holds her hand a little tighter. Like she's afraid she'll be set down too.
Kairos (thinking): And the cup is silver. Lucas said they gave him one the night he was adopted.
Father Ambrose Vane: Sister. Show them there is nothing to fear.
Cassie takes the cup. Her hands don't shake. They never do.
She drinks.
Sister Cassie: ...
Sister Cassie: I was angry a moment ago. About that woman. I know I was.
Sister Cassie: I can't find it.
Father Ambrose Vane: Because it's gone. That is mercy.
Sister Cassie: I've drunk from that bowl every Sunday since I was six. I can't remember my mother's face. The Office calls that grace.
Father Ambrose Vane: It is grace.
Sister Cassie: Then why does it feel like being robbed?
Father Ambrose Vane: Cassie.
Sister Cassie: I've kept my vows my whole life, Father. That's exactly why I can't stay.
She unpins the Office badge from her collar and sets it on the rim of the fountain. Carefully. As if it might still be holy.
Sister Cassie: I don't want to hear "told you so."
Kairos: I wasn't going to.
Theo: I was.
Dr. Naomi: Theo.
Sister Cassie: You said you had no bread. I brought you some. Don't make it strange. (if c_cass_joke)
Sister Cassie: I hesitated on a roof. I don't know what I believe now. I know I'm done hesitating.
Sister Cassie: If you'll have me.
Sister Cassie: You told me your name on that roof. I wrote it down. The Office never writes down names. (if c_cass_name)
Kairos: You tried to burn me.
Sister Cassie: I tried to arrest you. Father Vane tried to burn you. Details matter.
Sgt. Agnes: She's got a point.
Kairos (thinking): The moon slides over the sun. Every clock in the square stops for one second.
Kairos (thinking): I feel it in my teeth.
The Seam splits open above the festival. Five rifts at once.

Cassie joins the party.

Gameplay: Festival of the Mercy (defense, Festival Square). Five rifts at once. Keep the Vices off the crowd.

Choose 3 · "Festival of the Mercy": All eight of you, for the first time. Choose your three.

Kairos: During the fight, I saw it again. Every Vice turned the same way at once.
Theo: They're not attacking anymore. They're migrating. All toward one place.
Sgt. Agnes: Where?
Theo: The Registry of Births.
Lucas: Every birth record in Meridian.
Lucas: And one blank one.

Scene 13 · The Registry

NIGHT. THE REGISTRY OF BIRTHS.

Lucas: My father's keys. He doesn't know I took them.

Kairos: He will.

Lucas: Then I'd better make it worth it.

The Stacks. Shelves that go down further than the lamps reach. Every drawer is a person.

Dess: It smells like old paper. And… cold. Can a smell be cold?

Lucas: They say it's swept every morning. Nobody's ever seen dust down here. Nobody's ever seen the sweepers.

Kairos (thinking): Drawer after drawer. Names I know. Matteo. Rosa. Tessa, filed last spring with the wrong birthday.

Kairos (thinking): The whole Market Ring, in order. And a gap where I should be.

Sgt. Agnes: Gates ahead. Two teams, two routes. Each team opens the gates for the other.

Puzzle: The Stacks · The House gates

- □ The first gate has a brass plaque: "The Tenth Door opens to the Goat."
- Options: **Capricorn** □ / Aries / Taurus
- On success: Lucas: Capricorn. The Office's own sign. Of course.
- On a miss: Lucas: The Goat. Think of the sign with horns and a fish tail.
- □ The second plaque: "The Third Door opens to the Twins."
- Options: Libra / **Gemini** □ / Pisces
- On success: The gate grinds open.
- On a miss: Dess: Twins. Two of something.
- □ The last plaque is worn almost smooth: "The Twelfth Door opens to the Fish."
- Options: Cancer / Scorpio / **Pisces** □
- On success: Kairos: Pisces. My sun sign, if I had a chart.
- On a miss: Agnes: Fish. Not crabs. Not scorpions.

Party split: stacks

Team A prefers: Kairos, Lucas, Agnes

Team B prefers: Big Boy Bram, Naomi, Theo

At the bottom: a vault door. INTAKE WINDOW 1.

Kairos (thinking): I touch it. And I see myself. Older. Standing at this window, a long line of people behind me, shouting at someone I can't see.

Kairos: I've been here.

Dess: You can't have. Nobody's allowed down here.

Kairos: I know. I've still been here.

Scene 14 · Intake Window 1

Kairos (thinking): A waiting room big enough for a whole city. Rows and rows of empty chairs. Every chair has a number.

Kairos (thinking): And at the far end, behind a desk the size of a house, something made of moonlight in a clerk's coat.

Horaios: Intake Window 1. Take a number.

Sgt. Agnes: Is that… the Moon?

Dess: A Kosmokrator. One of the powers behind the birth charts. I've only ever seen the word in my father's notes.

Horaios: Name. Hour of birth. Sign here. Next.

Horaios: …No number. That one has no number. That isn't allowed.

Party loss: 1

Kairos (thinking): Everyone else is stamped. Processed. Grey.

Kairos: Please. Hold it one more time.

Kairos (thinking): The minute stops. And it turns its head. And looks at me. Inside the stopped minute.

Horaios: You're not the only one who's done this before.

Horaios: Processing.

Kairos (thinking): Lucas breaks through the grey. I don't know how. I think it's the vow.

Lucas: Not him. Not again.

The hand closes around Lucas instead. Behind Horaios, a gate of white light opens.

Kairos: LUCAS—

Horaios: Irregular. But acceptable.

Lucas: You pulled me out of a fire once. My turn.
Lucas: Don't you dare forget me.
Kairos: I can't. I never forget anything.
Lucas: Good. Then come get me.
The Gate closes.
The hall is just a dark room. Rows of chairs. A number on every one.
Kairos (thinking): …
Kairos (thinking): Mine doesn't have one.
Kairos (thinking): His does now.
The others gasp back to colour. The ceiling starts to come down.
Sgt. Agnes: Kairos. Up. Now.
He doesn't move. Bram picks him up for the second time this week, and runs.
The Registry collapses behind them, with every birth record in Meridian inside it.
Kairos (thinking): Dawn. A rooftop. Seven of us. One empty space.
Below, the Chancellor's voice from every speaking-horn in the city.
Chancellor Augustin Crane: Last night, heretics attacked the Registry of Births and destroyed it. My son Lucas was taken by them.
Chancellor Augustin Crane: If you see these people, do not approach them.
Big Boy Bram: He knows we didn't take him. He has to know.
Sgt. Agnes: He knows. It's just a better story this way.
Sister Cassie: Welcome to how the Church does things.
Big Boy Bram: Kairos. I saved you toast. From last night. It's cold. Sorry. (if c_breakfast)
Kairos: It's perfect, Bram. (if c_breakfast)
Theo: Kairos. Where did it take him?

> **Player choice** · Kairos: Where did it take him?
> ☐ **I don't know. But I'll find out.**
> **Theo:** Then I'm building you something to find out with.
> ☐ **Somewhere I've been before.** (sets c_been)
> **Theo:** …You keep saying that.
> **Kairos:** I keep meaning it.

Kairos (thinking): I remember every word Horaios said. Every inch of that hall. Every chair.
Kairos (thinking): He said not to forget him. As if I could.
Kairos (thinking): Fine. I'll go and get him.
Theo: Then, assistant. First assignment: we find him. (if c_job)
Kairos: Is this one paid? (if c_job)
Theo: No. (if c_job)
Lyra: You held the minute for him again. Twice this week.
The man in the black cloak: Three times. He thinks it's his.
Lyra: And Horaios moved inside it.
The man in the black cloak: Then the Moon remembers me. Good. That means he's awake.
Lyra: He asked me who I was.
The man in the black cloak: Did you tell him?
Lyra: No.
Kairos (thinking): (On the man's chest, under the black cloak: a clock face with no hands.)
Lyra: He told the inventor he's been there before. The hall. (if c_been)
The man in the black cloak: He has. Many times. (if c_been)
The man in the black cloak: It's too early. He has to come to me on his own this time.
Lyra: And when he does?
The man in the black cloak: Then I go home.
A white room. Rows of desks. Lucas, in a clerk's uniform, filling in a form at Window 1.
He reaches the line that says NAME. And stops. Pen hovering.
He doesn't know what to write.

CHAPTER 2: THE ARCHIVE

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To be continued.